The World Forgetting, By the World Forgot

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/30479364.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst with a Happy Ending, Let Catra (She-Ra) Say Fuck, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Sad start with a soft ending I promise, Human Catra (She-Ra), Memory Loss, Memory Alteration, Catra & Glimmer Friendship (She-Ra), Catra & Bow Friendship, GlimBow are the heroes we need and deserve, Plot Twists, Fake Science, Established Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Occasional skippable smut, Inspired by Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind

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Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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by motherofchimeras

Summary

When Catra and Adora first met, they believed they were soul mates. After an awful fight, Adora is forced to reckon with the idea that the love of her life chose to literally delete her from her memories. What was Adora to do but the exact same thing? Prime Enterprises offered the perfect treatment to heal her pain and let her start life anew. Only, it didn't go exactly as planned, and nothing is as it seems.

This an AU that combines She-Ra with the film: Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind. However, it is not a total copy of the movie. It is a borrowing of the core idea and theme.

You can erase someone from your mind. Erasing them from your heart is another story.

Notes

If you haven't seen the movie, you should. However, it's not necessary to understand the story. This isn't going to be an exact copy of the movie by any means, more of a borrowing of the core idea and playing with the theme. Eternal Sunshine is my favorite movie of all time. I hope to do it justice!

Eternia Beach

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Steel blue eyes opened to the grey overcast light of her bedroom. Adora groaned as ran her fingers through her disheveled blonde hair trying fruitlessly to soothe her throbbing headache. How much had she drank the night before? She couldn't remember. Finally she reached over to cease the relentless noise of her phone alarm.

"Perfect," Adora mumbled to herself as she read through the security message on the front of her phone. Due to a malfunction in the overnight update, there had been a major data loss on her device. Only items that were backed up to the cloud were saved. She made a mental note to ask Bow if he could figure out a way to get more back than that.

She dismissed the message and noticed another disappointing thing: the date. It was Valentine's Day, a day that was supposed to bring joy, but seeing as she had been single for as long as she could remember, she did not have any warm and fuzzy feelings about it. Maybe that's why she had gotten so drunk on a weeknight?

She stretched and lumbered out of bed to start her morning routine. Her workout was going to be skipped, but she managed her way through showering, getting ready for work, and heading out the door. As she walked down the sidewalk to the train station, she could not shake this unusual feeling—-being on the verge of tears but not knowing why. "Get it together, Adora," she thought to herself, "There's no reason to be this sad." And truly, by her estimation, there wasn't. She had a job she loved, amazing best friends, and a loving family. Sure, she was single. That was fine. Plenty of happy, successful people are single.

This was the mantra she kept repeating to herself as she continued that long walk to the station. Once she took her seat, she pulled up her phone again to try to reconnect her various accounts. The problem was – she could not remember the password for anything but her work email. Either she drank away the last remaining brain cell in her head last night or she had taken that seminar at work about phishing too seriously and made impossible passwords. She sighed and added that to her to do list for her next dinner with Glimmer and Bow. At least their numbers were still in her phone.

She sat silently people watching for lack of any other entertainment. The car was filled with sleepy people on the way to their own 9 to 5's as usual. Only, many were dressed in bright reds and pinks, no doubt to celebrate the holiday. Someone even had a giant stuffed animal; she stared at it for too long trying to decide what the animal was. It reminded her of a fox and was holding a balloon that said, "U R PURRFECT." Weird. The owner of said creature looked at her suspiciously, and she turned her focus up and away like she was watching for her stop.

The next was a stop for a transfer to the line that said its destination was Eternia Beach. She was suddenly taken by the strongest urge to go there. Whether it was the gloom in her mind or the idea of having to sit at work all day watching others receive gifts, she wasn't sure. All she knew was that in this moment, nothing felt more important than getting off this train and going there. A beach? In February? Sure, it felt silly, but…

She leapt up from her seat once the train came to a stop and rushed to get a transfer ticket. Before her logical brain had a chance to talk her out of it, she was seated now in a mostly empty train car with a new destination. After she caught her breath, she steeled herself for having to make her call in. She *rarely* ever called in to work, and she was such an awful liar she had never attempted to do it falsely. When her boss answered, she sped through her excuse without giving her a chance to respond, "Hey! It's Adora. I can't come in today; I'm not feeling well. Think it's something I ate! I'm so sorry." Thankfully, her

sterling record seemed to help in that matter. There were no further questions asked and she was let go with a wish of feeling better. “I hope I do too,” she thought to herself when she finished the call.

Standing on the sand in her winter work clothes any other day would probably make her feel like she was losing her mind. However, in this moment as she stood on the shore and watched the rising sun play off the sparkling water, she felt like an itch was being scratched in her soul. Something that felt very off, very wrong since the moment she woke up… started to right itself. Though, it did not last long. She walked the beach for a while, smiling casually at a couple who jogged by. Jogging on the beach together in the winter. True love. It hurt.

After lingering and positively ruining her leather boots, she made her way back up to the strip of shops that lined the shore. Most were only opened for tourist season, but after walking for a while she found a small diner that was open year-round. She took a seat alone at a booth and ordered a coffee and breakfast from the overly cheerful waiter.

While she sipped her coffee, she continued inspecting what she was able to recover in her phone. There was no rhyme or reason to what was left untouched. So peculiar. She looked up when she heard another voice, and saw a young woman sitting at a booth facing her but a few seats away. She was accepting her own cup of coffee from the waiter, and once he had turned his back away she uncapped a tiny airplane bottle of whisky and poured it in. Adora smirked and thought perhaps she should have tried a bit of the hair of the dog too. The woman caught her eyes and lifted her mug as if to say cheers with a wink.

Her cheeks reddened and she felt embarrassed for having been caught staring. She managed an awkward smile back as she raised her own mug before deciding to pretend to be very taken by the local paper she had picked up on the way in. “God, she’s cute,” she thought to herself. She was wearing a maroon beanie that short brown hair was peeking out of on the front and sides.

Her eyes from what she could see were two different colors, unless it was some trick of the light. There was a word for that condition, Adora thought, but she couldn't come up with it. She was sporting a leather jacket that Adora thought would make her look intimidating were it not for those playful eyes.

She shook her head and tried to dismiss the thoughts. It wasn't right to be sitting here and obsessing over a stranger. All she had done was acknowledge that she caught her adding a little relaxation to her morning. When her breakfast finally came, she allowed herself a furtive glance in the direction of the other woman. Her attention now was on a sketchbook that she had laid out on the table in front of her, and she had headphones on with pointy ears on top of them. Why was everything about her so cute? "Is it wrong that it makes me feel better to know someone so attractive is also having breakfast alone on Valentine's," she mused to herself. This was the kind of thing she would post on her social media if only she could log in to any of it. Her phone pinged with a text:

Glimmer: Happy Valentine's to my Galentine! Love you!

Adora: You too. Hope you and Bow have a big night ;) Might need to come see you two this week. My phone's doing some weird stuff.

Glimmer: Of course! Just let me know and we'll make a night of it.

After breakfast she took some time to wander the shore a little longer before the next train. She supposed if she really wanted to, she could make it in to work for a half-day. Except… she didn't really want to. Something about today made her want to go curl back up in bed and see if tomorrow was different.

When she got to the train platform, she was surprised to see that the other woman was there too. She was posted up against a column looking every bit the part of a cool, tough girl except for those silly headphones. She glanced over Adora's way and gave her a coy smile and waved. She returned the gesture as smoothly

as she could, but did not press any further. She was already having a weird day, she didn't want to add rejection to it as well. “Why am I such an awful flirt,” she thought to herself. If Glimmer were here, she’d be pushing her down the platform and telling her, “Hot girl is smiling at you, Adora! Go go go!”

When they were on the train, the ‘hot girl’ in question decided to sit in front of her despite having the whole train car to themselves for the most part. She still had her headphones on and resumed sketching away. With her this close, Adora could smell her perfume. Something about it felt like home. She was in the middle of scolding herself mentally for smelling strangers, when the other woman spun around in her seat and boosted herself up on her knees to look over the back at her.

“Hey.” Her voice was truly something else. It had this beautiful rasp to it, and with the way she uttered this one word it felt like the word ‘hey’ ought to be retired for everyone else. It was this woman’s alone.

“Hi.” She smiled up at her and hoped to be forgiven for her utter lack of smoothness.

“How far are you going, dummy?”

“Heart Station. You?”

“Me too! What are the odds?” She laughed to herself as she stared at Adora more intently, as though she was trying to analyze her. “Do I know you?”

“I don’t think so,” Adora figured she couldn’t forget this beautiful face. In their few moments of knowing each other, she could pick those freckles out of a line-up. “Nice to meet you though, I’m Adora.” she held up a hand and other woman awkwardly took it over the seat.

“Do you ever go to the coffee shop on Oakhurst?” Adora nodded and she laughed. “That must be it! I’ve been a coffee lackey there since I started college a few years ago. I’m sure I’ve served you

there. You probably don't recognize me because I cut all my hair off. Used to be crazy long. Hmm.. Let me guess…" Here it was again, that intense analytical stare that Adora could not hide from, not that she wanted to. "You're an athletic type. Probably a skinny vanilla latte as a treat?"

"Nope, I'm a plain drip or cold brew woman myself." The other woman smiled and seemed satisfied by this answer, and Adora's heart soared.

"Dummy, I'm sorry I misjudged you. You're no soccer mom. You've got taste." She laughed again.

Adora laughed along with her, if only for the pleasure of hearing that addictive noise. She was feeling much more at ease now. "So, tell me, do you call all of your former customers dummy or am I special?"

"Ha! Nope," she grabbed her sketchbook and opened it up again to show Adora. She had done a rough sketch of her on the beach in her work clothes. "Gotta be a dummy to ruin nice clothes like that."

The blonde reached for the book and the other woman released it. It was a rather good likeness for being a rough draft. "You know, now I'm a little worried you're actually stalking me. I bet you weren't going to Heart Station til I said I was. Come to think of it, you haven't even given me your name. Very suspicious."

"You caught me, Adora, I've been sent here to kill you." She smirked and grabbed for the book back.

"Not until you tell me your name." She held it up and outside of the other woman's reach.

"Only if you promise not to make jokes about it," she threatened. Adora crossed her heart. "Catra. Now give it!"

She handed the sketchbook back as promised and looked quizzically at the other woman. "Am I missing something? Not a

very funny name."

Catra rose an eyebrow at her and pulled her headphones back up off her neck. "Um, hello. Cat…ra? I guess I learned to lean into it or whatever, but, god damn, the number of stupid cat and mice jokes, girls hitting on me by saying they're going to make me purr, asking me if I'm in heat, all that shit. So annoying."

"I don't get it," Adora continued to look at her blankly. "What's a cat?"

"The fuck, Adora. Cats. The Internet's favorite pet. Come on. You *know* what a cat is, quit bullshitting. This is the weirdest way someone has joked about this with me."

Adora frowned and said with all the sincerity she could muster, "I'm not teasing you. I really don't know. I didn't have any pets growing up, and I'm kind of lame at Internet stuff. I can't even login to any of my accounts today."

"Oh, dummy, I am going to educate you til we get off this train," she swung out of the seat and stood beside the row. "May I?"

Adora scooted over and Catra joined her. She was close enough that she could feel her body warmth. Catra whipped out her own phone and pulled up a gallery of photos, "This is my cat, Melog. He's the cutest cat in the world, so honestly you've already seen the best of the species."

"Wow," Adora cooed as she looked at the pictures. How had she gone her whole life without seeing such a creature? Suddenly, the joke about the headphones made sense. "I think I love cats already."

"Geez, take him out to dinner first." Catra winked and then moved on to showing some videos of him running around what she thought was her living room. After a few more minutes of giggling together during her feline education, Catra put her phone away. "What brought you out to a cold ass beach in February anyway? If you don't mind me asking. I wanted a little change of scenery and

some peace and quiet myself. But... it looks like that's not where you started the day going."

"It's kind of complicated," Adora admitted and looked down as she started to pick at her nails anxiously.

Catra lightly tapped at her hands, "Hey, stop that. You're going to fuck up your cuticles."

Something about the gesture felt so familiar and intimate. It was nice. "Bad habit, ha. I don't know why really. I was on my way to work, and I looked up and saw the switch coming up for the beach. It sounded a lot better than going to work and seeing everyone get roses and chocolate all day."

Catra laughed. "Anything's better than Valentine's Day. Biggest commercial scam of a holiday."

"This one's not so bad," Adora said so quietly the other woman barely heard her.

"I have to agree." She gave her a genuine, excited smile. Something about her told Adora that this smile was special, a secret that most people don't get to see.

After chatting with each other about a myriad of silly things, the stop for the Heart Station came up. As they stood at the platform about to depart from each other, it was clear neither wanted to say goodbye.

Catra bit her lip and cast her gaze down at her shoes for a moment as though in deep debate. "You know," she looked up into the blue eyes of the taller woman, "Since you're playing hooky anyway, you should come with me to my apartment. You could meet Melog in real life and all."

"I don't know," Adora started and Catra frowned, "If I meet the best cat in the world first, that's awfully cruel to all of the others I'll meet."

Relief poured back over the Catra’s face again and she grabbed for Adora’s hand and she let her take it with no resistance, “Eh, they’ll get over it. Come on.”

A cat turned out to have many interesting features Adora had not anticipated. Melog was sitting in her lap now and relaxing. His paws were wiggling and needling at her pants and she felt grateful for the thick fabric. “Is he trying to hurt me,” she asked Catra who was across the room in the kitchen of her apartment.

“He’s just making biscuits. Nothing to be scared of,” Catra teased as she finished pouring them glasses of water. She came back in and joined the two on the couch. “Right, Melog? You won’t hurt the pretty lady. Will you?” She scratched underneath his chin and the rumbling sound emanating from him grew louder. “I seriously can’t believe you’ve never seen a cat before. Is some kind of a trick to murder me or get in my pants?”

“Maybe.” Adora stroked the top of the animal’s head. "I guess we'll have to wait and see."

“Hey, Adora. I should warn you.” Catra moved into her space so that their lips were nearly touching. “I’m rather hard to kill.”

Somehow, as though they were communicating telepathically, Melog knew it was time to hop away and explore another room of the apartment.

Adora slipped one of her hands behind Catra's neck and brought her in to make up the last bit of distance. When they kissed, it felt like every bit of that gray dread she had woken up with was washed away. It was replaced with the red lips she was hungrily slotting into her own, the blue and honey-colored eyes peeking out from heavy lids, and the golden-brown skin she touched her fingers to.

When their lips parted to allow them to catch their breath, Catra leaned her forehead into hers and wrapped her arms around her waist. "Mmm, forget what I said about Valentine's. If it's

responsible for us meeting to do this, it's my new favorite holiday." Adora could not agree more.

Adora practically ran the whole way from the bus stop to her apartment. She must look insane, she thought. Tears were flooding down her face the whole time, but at least the rain was helping to mask that. When she got into the lobby of her complex, she stood shivering in the bottom floor. She shook herself off as best as she could on the rubber mat, but it was to no avail. She was a wreck in more ways than one.

She approached the wall of mailboxes and began to unload her mail into her soaking wet hands. It was mostly junk at least. While she was closing her box back up, a neighbor approached and opened his box. “Aw man,” he whined as he flipped through his stack, “You know it’s sad when the only Valentine’s Day cards you get are from your mother.” Adora gave an attempt at a laugh back.

“At least you’ve got Catra. You two are so cute together,” he said cheerily, “Are you doing anything special?”

“Uh, I don’t know.” She looked down at his stack of mail, thinking about how he’d soon have a letter explaining that.

“Gosh. Hopefully Catra took care of it, it is tomorrow ya know. Good luck with getting a reservation anywhere before March if not.”

“Yeah, thanks, I’ve got to go to sleep. Bye.” She hurried off down the hall and up the stairs to her place.

She entered her apartment and threw down the mail. It was only eight o’clock. Far earlier than her typical bedtime, but she was told once she took the medicine she would be knocked out within a few minutes. She sighed as she looked around the apartment. It already looked empty. Missing something. Someone. Why not make her mind match?

She read back over the instructions one more time to make sure she didn't miss anything. She put on the pajamas they provided and looked at herself in the mirror. The next time she saw herself, everything would be better. That's what she was promised.

She went through the house making sure to turn off all of the lights, and glanced outside before pulling the last set of blinds. She could see on the street the unmarked van she was told would be carrying the technicians and their equipment. It really was time.

She sat down on the side of her bed, stared at the pill for far too long, and almost talked herself out of taking it. Then she remembered. *Catra did it first* . There was no need for her to suffer. Before she lost her resolve, she quickly took the pill and laid down. She could already feel her consciousness fading. In the morning, it would all be over. She would be free. Ready to start anew.

Chapter End Notes

> Let me know what you think so far! Comments bring me joy that I would never erase.

Everybody's Got to Learn Sometime

Chapter Summary

> Adora consults Glimmer, Bow, and a series of professionals. Catra and Adora get comfortable.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Hey. I'm so sorry to drop by without calling first," Adora choked out the words between gasping breaths. "I just really needed to talk this through with someone."

Glimmer stared back in panic before reaching out and wrapping her arms around her in a tight, comforting hug. "It's okay; we're always here for you. Come on, let's go sit down." She grabbed her hand and led her to the living room of their small home. They sat down on the couch, and Glimmer began rubbing her hand down her back soothingly as Adora tried to collect herself.

Bow walked into the room with a similar panic on his face before he tried to force himself to be neutral. "Hey, Adora. Do you want some water or anything?"

"No, I'm fine, I just," she put her head in her hands and sighed in frustration. "I don't know what's going on with Catra. We had that stupid fight the other day, and I thought all we needed was space."

"Uh-huh," Bow sat down on the other side of Adora, casting a knowing glance over to Glimmer.

"But… you know, it's two days until Valentine's, and I thought this is stupid, we need to get past this. I tried to call her earlier today, and she changed her number," she pulled out her phone and showed the failed calls. "So I go by the coffee shop, and she's there at the front, taking orders. I almost didn't realize it was her;

she cut all her hair off. Then she smiled and greeted me like I was anyone else...like I'm not her girlfriend of three years. She asked me my name! I left and came straight here. It's ridiculous. I don't know why she's being so childish."

"Adora," Bow spoke her name like he was talking to a wounded animal. "Have you checked your mail today?"

She looked bewildered but answered, "Yes. What? Why?"

Glimmer looked across the couch and gave him her best 'shut the fuck up' eyes. "Listen, maybe it's time to move on if she's going to act like that. A clean break."

"No, Glimmer, she deserves to know," he declared as he hopped up and headed over to their office. He came back with a form letter. "We got this in the mail this morning."

Adora took the paper and began reading the truth with bloodshot, weary eyes. "To GLIMMER, BOW: We at Prime Enterprises have been authorized to inform you that our patient CATRA elected to utilize our services on FEBRUARY 11. Due to this treatment, CATRA will have no memory of the subject: ADORA & RELATIONSHIP. Please do not mention this topic to her again, as it could severely affect her mental health and healing. CATRA may have memory gaps that may exclude CATRA from knowing you, GLIMMER, BOW, and specific memories attached to ADORA & RELATIONSHIP. Attempting to correct the memory of CATRA will be both negative to the healing of her brain and go against her sincere wishes. Thank you for your support and understanding, Prime Enterprises, Dr. Hordak & Co."

The other couple sat in dead silence as they watched her read. After a minute of staring blankly down at the paper, she finally spoke. "Is this a joke? This can't be real. There's… there's no fucking way this is real."

"We looked it up," Glimmer sighed. "I guess it's an experimental treatment for… trauma… or unwanted memories. "

"THAT doesn't make any sense, Glimmer. We had ONE big fight. ONE. That… she wouldn't," Adora flew up from her seat on the couch and began pacing around the living room. "We didn't even break up! How the fuck do you go from needing space to I'd like to forget you and the last three years of my life?!"

Bow started to tear up himself. "You know Catra… she's impulsive and kind of… um, well, she expects the worst sometimes. Maybe she thought you weren't going to make up? Like this was the only way to protect herself?"

"If you and Glimmer had a fight, would you want to erase her?" Adora was roaring with anger and devastation now. Nothing made sense. "You wouldn't, Bow! God damn it, Catra, why would you do this," she started crying again and sat down on the floor in a huff. "I don't know what I'm supposed to do."

Glimmer sighed. "There's nothing you can do about this, Adora. It's unfortunate, but it's true. I'm so sorry. I wish we'd have known... we could've stopped her."

"You don't think.. that… well maybe if I tell her, she'll remember? That… maybe since it was so recent," Adora started stammering, pulling for straws at anything she could think of. "Bow, you… you know medical technology stuff."

"We read about it on their website all morning," Bow admitted as he shook his head slowly. "It's not like that. It's… it's like brain damage. Like the letter said, it could break her sense of reality."

"I don't accept that. I refuse," Adora snatched the letter back up from where she dropped it on the ground as she hopped back up to her feet. "I'm just going to go there and talk to these people. Catra wasn't thinking straight. They took advantage of her. She never would've done this… she didn't know we were going to fix it. I'm going to fix this."

"Adora," Glimmer and Bow both said at nearly the same time.

"Guys, I know you mean well, but I have to try, okay? I have to try. I'll text you when I'm home," she rushed out of their home as quickly as she had entered in.

———

"I've never been kissed like that in my whole life," Adora admitted sheepishly. "Though… I guess… I haven't really kissed anyone in a couple of years."

"What a loser," Catra gently moved into her space, guiding her to lay down on the couch. Her new friend happily complied. Once she was straddling the blonde, she leaned into her ear and whispered, "Neither have I."

"No way. How's that possible? You're.. so hot.. and charming and…"

Catra laughed to herself again before she brought her into another deep kiss. As they parted, she nibbled her bottom lip and then laid her head to rest on the other woman's chest. She could hear her heartbeat, strong and fast. "Give it enough time; you'll see there's plenty not to like about me."

"Impossible," Adora whispered as she ran her fingers through the other woman's short hair.

"If you say so," she breathed a contented sigh. "You know, maybe we're not losers. Maybe we're soul mates, and the rest of the world knew not to fuck with us because it would be pointless."

"That must be it." As much as it sounded like the brunette was joking, Adora felt like it could be a real possibility. How many years had she been waiting for this kind of spark? And to find it like this?

"So, soul mate," she turned her head to be able to look back up into those gorgeous blue eyes, "Got any plans for the rest of the day?"

"Nope, I'm all yours." Adora couldn't believe how natural this felt.

"I like the sound of that," Catra propped herself back up on her elbows and kissed her skin above the dip of her top. "I have *some* ideas of how we can spend the day." She moved one of her legs so that it was between the blondes and pressed it into her center ever so slightly. "I'm also agreeable to more talking and cuddling. No pressure."

"You're using a *little* pressure down there," she joked with a coy smile. Her pale skin was transforming to bright red as heat flooded through her whole body.

"You are such a dork," Catra laughed, peeling her shirt back further with her fingers and tracing more kisses along her collarbone. "Why do I find it so sexy?"

"How embarrassing for you," Adora smirked as she glided her hands down the brunette's back, landing them on her ass where she squeezed. "I happen to find everything about you sexy."

"A strip mall," Adora mumbled to herself as she got out of the taxi. She had read every single word on Prime Enterprises' website on the ride. For all of the futuristic design and innovation the website promised, she couldn't believe it was housed between a nail salon and a pawn store. How Catra could have walked into this place and trusted them to do something to her brain was beyond her.

She pulled open the tinted door of the business to find, at least on the inside, it looked like a legitimate doctor's office. The lobby area had only one other person waiting: an elderly woman was sobbing as she clutched a box of what appeared to be cat toys. The receptionist looked up from his computer and smiled at her.

"Hello, Welcome to Prime Enterprises," the young blonde man greeted her from his desk. "How might we help you cast out the

shadows of your life today?"

Adora moved forward and stared at him incredulously. "I need to speak with the doctor immediately," she demanded and slammed down the paper she had brought.

The young man, whose name was Kyle, according to his nameplate, picked up the paper, and looked over it. "Are you Glimmer or Bow? I can help explain what this means; you don't need a doctor for that."

He was entirely too enthusiastic and cheerful for this place, Adora thought. She felt a growl attempting to rise in her throat but pushed it down. "No, I'm Adora," she explained in as even a tone as possible. "This has been a huge mistake, and I need to talk to Dr. Hordak right now."

Kyle smiled agreeably and turned back to his computer. He clicked around a few times before shaking his head. "I'm very sorry, Adora, but Dr. Hordak is with patients all afternoon. We could make an appointment--"

She cut him off. "No, I need to speak with him or another doctor, RIGHT. NOW." She banged her fist on the counter to emphasize her point. "PLEASE."

"Hello there," another voice called from the hallway. "Dr. Hordak is busy, but I'm available for any inquiries you might have!"

Adora turned around and looked into the eyes of a young woman, a few years older than her. She had long, lilac pigtails and a lab coat with the name "Dr. Entrapta" printed on it. "Yes, please, I need to--"

"OH, I recognize you. What an unexpected twist, Adora of Adora and Relationship. Come along," she turned on her heel and began quickly head back into the building.

Adora followed along, taking slow and deep breaths, trying to call herself down. Entrapta led her into a small office bearing her

name, and she closed the door behind them. She pulled out a recorder and began to turn it on before she suddenly paused, "Do you mind if I record this? I've never interviewed the subject of an erasure before. This will be stupendous data!"

"Fine," Adora grumbled, figuring it was better than fighting it. She needed to get this woman to help her.

"So, Adora of Adora and Relationship," she said after she started recording. "What would you like to know? With respect to patient privacy, I can't tell you many details, but I am happy to provide whatever data is considered public record."

"Were you one of the doctors that treated Catra," she asked hesitantly.

"Not a medical doctor. I am the lead technician and co-inventor," she beamed proudly. "I created the brain mapping software! Dr. Hordak and I worked closely to develop the procedure and related equipment." She turned to her computer, clicked around excitedly, then turned her monitor to show Adora a brain scan with various areas highlighted and marked with x's. "Now, I can't say for sure due to confidentiality, but hypothetically speaking, this could be a brain map showing where someone's memories related to someone like you were extracted."

Adora stared at the scan for a long time before speaking. It was practically littered with these red x's. The unusual technician was anything but subtle; this was Catra's mind, and now Adora knew precisely what had been taken from her. "I need your help. This isn't what she wanted. I know it. She wasn't in the right place at the time. Is there anything that can be done?"

Entrapta looked at her blankly as she considered the question. "Adora of Adora and Relationship--"

"Just Adora is fine."

"Adora, unfortunately, there has been no need to develop such a solution. Only the patient could request it, but the patient has no

recollection of the procedure."

"Okay, fine. If I can talk to her, I know that I can get her to understand," Adora said determinedly. "If she requested it, you would do it? It's possible?"

"Speaking with a patient about their procedure would be highly dangerous," she gestured at the scan, "As you can see, the patient's brain map was filled with connections to the subject. It would be very detrimental to their understanding of the nature of their own reality. It would generate A FASCINATING data set, but would be unfortunately unethical."

Adora started to tear up as she stared at the brain. "Dr. Entrapta," she implored, her voice shaking. "You don't understand. We were together for almost four years."

"One thousand, three hundred, and sixty-seven days if I recall correctly. It is the longest human relationship we have cured thus far."

"Cured," Adora whimpered.

"Dr. Hordak and I believe that by removing these unfortunate and painful distractions from our lives, we as human beings can function at the highest capacity," Entrapta repeated as though she was speaking to a potential investor.

Adora clenched her fists. Tears, born of despair and frustration, were streaming down her face now. "I need to talk to Dr. Hordak. Please. I have to know I did everything I could."

Entrapta drummed her fingers on her chin in thought. "Perhaps he would be interested in speaking with a subject. This is a unique opportunity!" She pressed down on a small object that was hanging from her ear and spoke, "Hello. Dr. Hordak? Adora of Adora and Relationship is here. She would like to speak with you. It's been an enlightening conversation!" Entrapta nodded along to the response. "We will see you in a moment." She smiled at Adora as she stood up from her desk, "You're in luck! He is in between

patients at the moment. Technically speaking, it's Mrs. Bastion's appointment time, but she won't remember the wait after the procedure. No harm done!"

Adora shook her head as she once again followed the lead of the energetic doctor. 'No harm done,' she thought with a sneer on her face. It seemed like the whole purpose of this place was to cause harm. Dr. Hordak's office was outfitted like a doctor's office with many mundane instruments Adora recognized. The man himself was seated at his desk while waiting for the two.

"Greetings," he said as he stood up briefly and extended a hand for Adora to shake.

She shook his hand with authority, putting every ounce of her frustration into it.

"My apologies that we are meeting under such *unusual* circumstances, Adora," he said cooly as he sat back down at his desk. He looked up at Entrapta, "Would you mind taking Mrs. Bastian to begin her mapping in lab number two? You may borrow Kyle if you need an extra set of hands."

"Of course, Dr. Hordak," she smiled happily and headed back out.

"Tell me, Adora, what is it that we might be able to do for you?" As he stared at her, she felt oddly exposed. He'd been privy to all the intimate moments of the last years of her life.

"There has to be a way to fix this," she said plainly, "To fix... Catra. I don't know what she told you, but we were happy. We had one stupid fight. She doesn't think clearly when she's upset."

"I am not able to tell you specific details, but suffice it to say that Ms. Catra was *not* happy," he pulled out a folder and began flipping through some notes. "She was quite devasted, and, now, I am told by one of our observers that she is happily back in work and school."

"That's because she doesn't know what she lost," Adora demanded, reaching for the folder, but the man pulled it back.

"I'm sure that Dr. Entrapta explained to you the ramifications for revealing such matters to her," he shifted his folders and pulled out another one that he handed to Adora. "For your trouble, we are willing to cure you of these imperfect memories as well. You will be as though you never knew this Catra. I know that your lives were, unfortunately, very intertwined, and I believe this is in your own best interest."

Adora took the folder but glared at him. "How can you be so cold? These are our lives... our memories. I can't believe this is even legal."

"Not cold, logical. You will find our many peer-reviewed research papers about our success in this field in that folder. Our unbiased observers have been able to track the lives of those who we have aided, they have seen all that they can be, and one hundred percent of our patients have started their lives anew without the burden of their past. There is no reason for you to suffer from this pain when your former partner has freed herself of it." He stood and gestured towards the door. "Take that with you, and consider my words. We could bring the light back to your life as soon as tomorrow."

"No, thanks," Adora clutched the folder against her chest all the same and rushed out the room.

When Adora got home, she sent off the quick "Home," text to the Best Friend Squad group. She noticed for the first time that it contained only the couple and herself now. Glimmer and Bow must have sent off several supportive responses; she could hear the phone vibrating on the bedside table. All of her mental and emotional energy was being spent reading through the papers in this damned folder. She thought perhaps it would contain some kind of answer; some other names of people to reach out to. There had to be an answer. By midnight, her mind swirling with all of the data, she realized there was only one. She stared at the

business card the doctor had included in the folder. Why should she suffer alone?

Chapter End Notes

Oof. The hurt.

Let me know what you think! I am curious to know the takeaways from both folks who are familiar with the movie and those who aren't.

Mapping Love

Chapter Summary

> Adora completes her brain mapping. Catra and Adora get closer. Bow and Glimmer are terribly confused.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Two full trash bags.

The taxi driver looked at her funny when he pulled up, but Adora assured him it wasn't actually trash. At least, it didn't feel like trash. She loaded her baggage into the trunk and sat in the backseat contemplating the emotional morning. She had woken up in time to swing by the cafe before she got to work cleaning her apartment. Catra was working behind the bar making drinks and joking with her coworkers. Adora didn't try to order. She simply stood in the corner, looking at the woman that was supposed to be her girlfriend— the undisputed love of her life. The barista looked her way with a quick nod of acknowledgment as though Adora was waiting on a drink. That's all she was now — a customer. A stranger.

A part of her hoped showing up like this would allow her to see that spark of recognition. Maybe there was a little piece of love left in her heart that their technology couldn't reach. Instead, she was left with cold reality. She lost her, and Catra seemed happier for it.

She went back home and began cleansing her life of anything that whispered Catra. The pamphlet said the more she could bring, the more accurate her brain mapping would be. It would also prevent her healing mind from being confused by things she couldn't remember. Thus, the two trash bags. They were packed with every little thing that brought her joy and reminded her of her girlfriend. Somehow her mind didn't wrap around the concept of

"ex." Is it really an ex-girlfriend when the version of them that was dating you blipped out of existence?

These thoughts and more were running through Adora's mind as she sat in the back of the taxicab. She hadn't warned Glimmer and Bow. They would try to talk her out of it, no doubt as they wished they could've Catra. She couldn't bear the thought of having to second guess herself again. The words of the research papers had promised release from her suffering, and that was the only thing bringing her comfort. Seeing how happy Catra seemed to be reminded her that she could be the same. She could start anew.

It was pouring rain when they pulled up to the strip mall. After thanking and paying the driver, she quickly grabbed the bags out of the trunk and ran in. No one else was waiting today. Kyle was sitting at the desk again and looking, as always, terribly cheerful.

"Adora! Welcome back," he said happily as he started to key in something on his computer. "Dr. Hordak told me to expect to see you this morning."

Of course, that arrogant doctor thought she'd be back. She held the bags awkwardly and nodded at him. "Thanks. What do I need to do with these?"

"You'll bring them back with you to the mapping. Wow, that's a lot of stuff," he noted as he looked over the desk. "I'm sure this must be hard. I don't know what I'd do if either of my partners erased me."

Adora felt annoyed that even this receptionist seemed to know about her sad situation. Honestly, he probably knew more than she did. No matter. She wouldn't know anything at all about it soon. "Yeah, it isn't great," she mumbled and was about to go sit down and wait until she heard a familiar female voice.

"Greetings!" Entrapta called from the hallway. "Follow me, and we'll get started on your pathway to healing!"

Adora felt like she was moving through jello as she followed behind the energetic scientist. Entrapta brought her into a room with an unusual chair at the center. It had had a piece over it that reminded her more of a blow dryer at a salon than medical equipment.

"As you read in the documents we shared," Entrapta started as she guided Adora to sit down and started to connect various lines to her skin, "We'll be connecting to your brain to map out the specific locations for the memories of Subject: Catra and Relationship. Utilizing the items you brought in and your personal narrative, we should get an accurate reading of where to eliminate the subject. Does that make sense?"

"I guess," Adora answered blankly. "Does it hurt?"

"For brain mapping, you won't feel anything. Tomorrow when you wake up after we do the extraction, you'll simply feel like you've had a night of heavy drinking," Entrapta assured her, continuing to fiddle with various connections before lowering the device onto her head. "Some people cry during the mapping, but that is to be expected. Do you have any other questions before we begin?" Adora shook her head no.

Entrapta moved back and away from her to start up her computer program. Adora felt a hum of machinery coming to life around her but, as promised, no pain. "Let's get started. Why don't you tell me how you and subject Catra met? The more detail, the better."

"At the beach in Eternia," Adora started shakily. She already felt like crying. This was going to be a long afternoon.

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"Is that so," Catra looked into the blonde's eyes. "Now that we both agree that we're sexy as fuck, what are your limits for this afternoon?"

"Oh," Adora thought about it for a moment, letting her hands slip up and onto the small of the other woman's back. "I think…

maybe… you know."

"Mm, but I just met you. I don't know. You have to ask for what you want," Catra teased.

Adora felt silly for being so embarrassed. She didn't bat an eyelash about following this practical stranger home or kissing her. And.. she really wanted to do more than that. Saying it, though, was hard.

"How about I tell you what I'd like to do, and you tell me if you want that," Catra proposed after the extended silence and Adora's face going beet red.

"That sounds so good," she confirmed, grateful for the help.

"How about," Catra sat up and placed a hand on her lower stomach. "We don't take all of our clothes off. You know, leave some mystery for future us," she glided her hand down and placed it on the button of Adora's pants. "And since we're doing this for the first time since high school, I'll sneak my hand in here and touch you like we might get caught."

"Yes, please, I want that." God, her head felt dizzy, though. Bad time for the hangover to make itself known again.

"Perfect," Catra smirked. She got up off the couch and the other woman. "Sit up for me?" Adora did as commanded, and Catra slipped in behind her, resting her back against the arm of the couch. She gently guided the blonde to lean into her. She brought one of her hands low again and undid Adora's work slacks. "Still good?"

"I'll be better when you're touching me," Adora huffed.

"So impatient," Catra chided her before she brought her lips against her neck, brushing them ever so lightly against her skin. At the same time, she slid her hand down and into her underwear. As she worked her fingers through the already very wet folds, Adora leaned back into her even further with a sharp inhale. "Tell

me if something isn't working for you, okay," she instructed her as she spoke quietly into her ear.

"Okay," Adora agreed breathlessly.

The warning wasn't necessary, it turned out. Catra had settled into the perfect rhythm and technique immediately for her body. Adora worried she might seem like she was faking it, but… god, it really did feel divine. Catra's free hand clumsily but successfully unbuttoned her shirt at the top so she could reach in and grab her breast. She slid under the blonde's bra and teased one of her nipples.

"I like that," Adora managed between gasps. She hadn't paid much attention to her breasts during self-exploration, but it was on the menu now that the brunette had pinched them and shown her the light.

"I like it too," Catra whispered in her ear, nibbling on the side. "I'm so glad I met you, Adora."

The sweet words, in combination with the pleasure of other woman's skilled fingers on her clit made her feel the edge coming quickly. "Fuck," she pressed back into the smaller woman, who braced herself against the couch.

"Let go," she whispered back, doubling down her efforts.

Within a minute that felt like an eternity, she felt the release finally and relaxed into the other woman as she continued soft loving touches through it.

"Fuck, that was hot," Catra said wistfully as she wrapped her arms around and snuggled her in close.

"You're hot," Adora tried to relax her breathing. "And really good at that."

"Thanks," Catra gave one of her little raspy laughs.

After cuddling for a while, Adora offered to return the favor. Catra was all too happy to let her. Despite her own nerves, it seemed as easy as Catra made it look… well, feel, more like it. She couldn't believe it; it had been so long since she'd touched anyone other than herself. Everything about them seemed in sync. When they finally untangled themselves from each other on the couch and righted their clothing, Adora took a mini-tour of the apartment while they stretched their legs.

"What made you decide to cut off all your hair," Adora asked as she was looking at some photos that the other woman had pinned up above her desk.

"You're going to think I'm stupid," Catra answered as she knelt down to pour food into Melog's bowl. "I woke up a couple days ago, and I just felt really weird. Like, I looked at myself in the mirror, and I felt like I didn't recognize myself. I don't know why I thought chopping off all my hair would help in the first place, but it did make me feel lighter. I like it."

"You look beautiful either way. Though with the short hair, you can see your cute face more." Adora confirmed as she smiled back at her. She only looked mildly annoyed at the cute moniker. "And that's not stupid. I felt the same way today, basically. I think that's a part of why I skipped work."

"Ooh, should I get my shears?" Catra came up and ran a hand through her long blonde ponytail. "I'm thinking undercut. Fully shaved is also an option as long as you have a good shaped head under here." Then she squeezed Adora's head like one might test the firmness of an avocado.

"Maybe another day," Adora laughed. "Meeting you… that's already made me feel better."

"I'm honored I could save you, princess," Catra didn't know where the pet name had come from. There wasn't anything princess-y at the moment about Adora, aside from her obvious beauty. Yet, it felt right.

Catra was brought out of her inner thoughts by her phone beeping at her from her pocket. She grabbed it and scowled, "Fuck! I forgot I have a meeting with my graduation advisor today."

"Shit, I'm so sorry," Adora went for the things that she had laid down by the couch.

"Hey, no need to apologize," Catra purred as she came up and wrapped her arms around her. "I had a great time getting distracted. Now, why don't you give me your number so we can have a proper date?"

They exchanged numbers, and Catra made a point of walking over to her desk and writing it on paper too. "I don't trust my phone these days. The other day I woke up, and it was all fucked up. Some kind of update gone wrong," she complained. "I am not taking my chances. Who knows how many chilly mornings I'd have to spend at the beach waiting to find you again."

"The same thing happened to me! It's so annoying." She shook her head, and taking the lead from Catra, she pulled out a small notebook from her bag to write down the other woman's number too. "I'm actually supposed to see my friend tomorrow about getting it fixed. He's a technology wiz. Would you like to come? I know… kinda early to meet the friends and all.. but we could make a double date out of it."

"Sounds like a plan to me. At this rate, we'll be married by next week. Not that I'm complaining." She grabbed her backpack and started towards the door after giving Melog a parting pet.

"I'll use the rest of my time off today to scout venues," Adora laughed and started to follow her out, but the cat stopped in front of her, mewing and wanting her attention. She bent down and petted him. "Bye, it was nice meeting you, Melog."

"That's so funny," Catra noted as she closed the door behind them. "He's actually kind of shy around strangers normally, but he

loves you already. He's got good taste."

"Maybe he's honored that he's my first cat friend."

Once the two had finally parted ways, Adora pulled out her phone to text Glimmer as she walked home.

Adora: I met someone today!

Glimmer : You met someone? Like a celebrity?

Adora : No, silly, a girl. It's crazy. We met on the train, and she's gorgeous and so funny and we kissssssed.. and other things [hot sauce emoji]

Glimmer : Wow.

Glimmer : I mean, I'm excited! That's just so fast for you. Tell me about mystery girl.

Adora : What if you meet her instead? Double date tomorrow night? She has weird stuff going on with her phone too. I thought Bow could help.

Glimmer : Sure, gotta make sure she's good enough for my bestie. You've already been through so much.

After some time confirming with Bow, the two had set up their double date. Adora wondered why Glimmer was being so dramatic about it. Usually, she'd be thrilled that Adora was even talking to someone. Though, it had been a very, very long time since that. She couldn't even remember trying to hit on a girl in the last few years. She really was rusty. At least it didn't feel that way with Catra where it mattered.

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Entrapta held up the last item from the trash bags. It was one of Adora's favorites. If she could keep anything, it would be this — a plush orange and brown tabby cat with blue and yellow eyes.

Catra had it custom-made for Adora as one of her gifts for their first Valentine's. Only she was allowed to use cat puns with the other woman. Anyone else would get a cutting joke back their way that made them never try again. But, for Adora, she was as soft as a kitten.

"She had that made for me for Valentine's. It's supposed to look like her if she was a cat," she managed barely. She had run out of tears at this point. She was just puffy eyes and broken speech now.

"Oh, I see it now!" Entrapta laughed as she held the cat and stared at its face. "Fascinating. I believe we have everything we need. Unless you have anything else you need to share, but I can see from the map we're already covering a wide area."

"I can't think of anything," Adora sighed as she rubbed her eyes and carefully avoided the various contact points for the wires.

"Fantastic. I'll get you disconnected, and then all you need to do is sit down with Dr. Hordak."

Entrapta released her from the various connections carefully. Adora felt like a plaything as she moved her arms and head. Despite only sitting down and talking for a couple of hours, she felt exhausted, like she'd run a marathon.

Finally, she was freed and led into the other doctor's room. He was once again behind his desk. When he looked up to see Adora, he smiled in a smug way that made her want to cancel the whole thing entirely, if only not to give him the satisfaction.

"Hello, Adora. I am so glad to see that you decided to take us up on the offer. Your suffering is almost at an end." He gestured to the seat in front of his desk. "We'll discuss the procedures for this evening, and I have some paperwork for you to fill out and give to Kyle before leaving."

She sat down, and Entrapta took this as her cue to leave, lingering only a moment to see if the man acknowledged her. He

didn't.

"I felt like I didn't really have much of a choice," Adora admitted. "I can't imagine going through life and knowing…"

"Exactly," Dr. Hordak said pleasantly. "This is why we developed these services. To cleanse us of the pain." He handed her a bottle with one pill rattling around in it. "Tonight, once you are ready to begin, you will turn off all the lights in your home and close the blinds. Our technicians will be waiting for this as their cue. Then, take this."

"What is it," Adora asked as she stared at the large lime green pill.

"It's merely a strong sedative. It will allow you to remain asleep safely while our team is at work. It is powerful, mind you. You will need to lay down immediately."

"Fine," Adora replied simply.

"I know it is difficult to see now," he dropped into a more comforting tone, "But this is truly for the best." He handed over some documents on a clipboard, "These are your release forms for this evening. There are also papers where you can list who, if anyone, you want to know about this procedure. We recommend anyone who would be likely to have shared many memories with you and this… Catra. Or anyone who would be likely to bring her up to you. We don't want anyone confusing you during your healing."

"Dr. Entrapta said that there are a lot of connections. What happens… if I do encounter something? Like if I missed something that Catra gave me or someone brings up a memory that isn't right?"

"The mind is a very interesting thing. It wants the world to make sense. It will find ways to bridge new connections, reconcile reality, and work towards healing."

"Oh, okay," she nodded. No wonder Catra didn't make anything of how she acted when she saw her the first time after the 'procedure.'

With that, he stood and ushered her out of his room. "It was a pleasure meeting you for now. Unfortunately, you will not recall this interaction."

Adora did not return the sentiment. She was done. Instead, she solemnly headed out to the lobby to work on her forms. She looked out the tinted windows and saw the rain still pouring down. Perfect.

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After a day of flirting on the phone, Adora was anxious to get to see Catra in person again. She felt nervous that it would be in the context of meeting Bow and Glimmer, but all the same, she figured they would love her as much as she already did. Eek. Love. That is not the right word to be describing your train hookup after one day. *Was* it a hookup? She didn't really know.

She was mulling all of this over when Catra walked through the door to the restaurant. They smiled at each other excitedly from across the distance. As soon as she reached the table, Adora stood to give her a hug that the other woman ended with a kiss.

"How was work? Not as good as freezing at the beach, I bet," Catra teased once they parted and sat down.

"Definitely not. It was okay. Just boring," Adora smiled. "Everyone was giving me funny looks all day, though. I guess I'm never going to call out again."

"Fuck em," Catra winked, "Everyone deserves time to do whatever they want. Life's too god damn short. That's what I say. So what should I know about your friends? Are they going to drill me?"

"Glimmer might," she laughed as she imagined her fiery best friend. "Bow's definitely the easy-going one out of the two, but

they're great. I think they'll like you."

After chatting for a bit and ordering their drinks, Catra left for the restroom. While she was gone, Bow and Glimmer entered, and they met Adora's eyes awkwardly. She wondered if maybe she did something weird with her hair or spilled something on her clothes. They were giving her the same look as the people at work. Finally, they joined her and seemed to have recovered.

"Hey," Glimmer said as she gave her a quick side hug. "We're so glad you wanted to go out."

"Yeah," Bow echoed carefully. "It's been.. a really, really long time since we went on a double date together. Since, like, freshman year with that girl from your soccer team."

Glimmer gave him eyes that she hoped read as *You're doing entirely too much.*

"It has been a long time," Adora confirmed, none the wiser. "I don't want to jinx it but—" she had started before she heard a raspy laugh behind her.

"If you don't want to jinx something, don't say it, dummy," Catra finished and hopped up onto the stool beside her. She turned to Glimmer and Bow and smiled. "Hi, Catra. Nice to meet you two. Now, which of you is Glimmer? Neither of you seems nearly sparkly enough." They looked dumbfounded as they stared back at her. After a few seconds of awkward silence, she frowned. "Sorry, tough crowd."

"Oh, no. You're fine," Bow assured her and tried to act normal. "Like we were saying, it's been forever since Adora had a date. We weren't sure you were real. Right, Glimmer?"

"Yep, it's unbelievable," Glimmer nodded and wondered when the waiter would be by to take their drink orders. "It's nice to meet you, Catra. We've been friends with Adora for a really long time. We're just… so glad she found someone."

"Thanks, I think," Catra said as she raised her eyebrows and looked at Adora.

"Oh, Bow," Adora decided to redirect the awkward moment as she pulled her phone out of her purse. "Like I told Glimmer, my phone's all messed up. From a cloud update or something? I don't know, but it's missing a ton of things, I think. My logins and stuff don't work."

"Yeah, same," Catra confirmed, pulling out her own. "I googled it and everything, but it doesn't seem to be a widespread problem. Maybe we're cursed."

"I will certainly take a look at that," Bow nodded dumbly and took Adora's phone. He understood the problem now, and there was definitely no fix. "Let me go call one of my coworkers really quick and check with them."

He got up from the table and headed back towards the bathroom. Glimmer seized the opportunity for a minute alone, "And I have to pee. We'll be right back! Order me a margarita… a huge one. Thanks!"

After they were out of earshot, Catra frowned at Adora and looked defeated. "Jesus, your friends already hate me. What did I do? I'm used to it taking at least 5 minutes of knowing me."

"What, no. Of course, they don't hate you," Adora stared into her eyes reassuringly. "They were acting weird with me before you even came back from the restroom. Maybe they had a fight on the way over or something?"

"I hope that's it," Catra said as she downed the rest of her mixed drink. "My fragile self-esteem can't handle this shit. Dealt with enough kids who hated me in school."

"Well, no matter what they decide," Adora leaned in and kissed her quickly. "I really like you."

"I really like you too," Catra said, scooting her stool closer so that they were together as a united front.

Glimmer and Bow stood back by the bathroom, watching the scene. "What the fuck, Bow?!" The shorter woman whisper yelled at him. "I don't understand how this happened."

"I guess they must have run into each other," Bow shrugged. "I mean, it makes sense kind of, right? They don't remember each other, but… they still are what the other person thinks is attractive."

"But like," she gestured over at the table where Catra and Adora were now arm wrestling for some inexplicable reason. The brunette grabbed Adora's knee under the table with her free hand, startling her for the win. "Look at them! They seem like they were before."

"It is super weird. How would they even run into each other anyway? If they took out Adora's memory of her at the cafe, they wouldn't have met there. Catra's still in school," he pondered while watching them. "I don't know. Maybe something in the procedure went wrong?"

"I guess," Glimmer narrowed her eyes at the couple. "I'm just worried… you read what it said about messing with their healing or whatever just mentioning them to each other."

"They seem fine. Maybe this is for the best… Adora's happy again, and we get Catra back as a friend. That's a good thing," Bow looked emotional as he contemplated this. When he realized that his partner in crime for his more nerdy pursuits wouldn't even recognize him, it was a huge loss.

"Still. I am going to contact this place tomorrow morning and demand answers. God, these useless lesbians. This seriously could only happen to them." Glimmer found herself smiling despite her nerves as now the two women were laughing over something so hard they were holding onto each other to not fall off their tall

stools. "They do look happy. Okay. Let's make it through this weird dinner without screwing things up anymore. Got it?"

"Got it," Bow confirmed, and they headed back over finally.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for the very belated update! Writing this one makes me a little sad, but I really enjoy the story! Let me know what you think. :)

Each Wish Resigned

Chapter Summary

> Adora begins the process of reevaluating her memories before they depart. Catra and Bow bonding in every timeline. Catra's POV is revealed, and the path that led to her to Prime Enterprises becomes more clear.

Chapter Notes

> Okay, team, we're juggling a lot of timelines/POVs here! I hope it still makes sense! This is a big departure from the movie because we only saw Joel's (Adora's role) POV in all timelines real/memory wise.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora’s bleary eyes scanned the room, trying to determine where she was. It was a small room containing a familiar chair and an impressive computer set-up befitting a space program. For sure, she was in Prime Enterprises, but how did she get here? The door opened, and she turned to ask what was going on. Instead, her voice caught in her throat. She watched as Dr. Entrapta and another Adora walked into the room. After setting her up and answering her questions, the scientist returned to stand behind her computer screens. Adora walked up to Dr. Entrapta and waved a hand in front of her face. At first, she didn't react at all. Then, after she finished with her furiously fast keyboard clicks, she looked over.

"Yes, Adora Prime? At least I think you are the prime Adora. How may I help," she asked pleasantly.

"What's happening? Why are there two of me?" She pointed over to the version of herself that was beginning to cry already.

"I suspect that I am currently out in the material world altering your memories right now while your corporeal self is sleeping in

bed," Dr. Entrapta explained as though she was detailing something simplistic. "How fascinating! Your consciousness must be following my work."

Adora frowned at this possibility. All she wanted was to go to sleep and wake up happy. "I have to relive everything?"

"No idea! I am merely an approximation of your memories, and I did not come preloaded with this knowledge," Dr. Entrapta explained before she turned her attention back to her job.

In a few seconds, she was shunted further backward through her memories' timeline. Now she was in the cafe the morning she tried to see Catra before Adora knew what she'd done. This time, instead of spectating, she *was* herself in the memory, standing in front of the register.

"Catra, we need to talk, please," she felt herself say, though she knew now how hopeless that was.

"Sure, if you have questions about the menu, I can help," she answered back with a warm smile.

Adora stared at her, analyzing the details of her face. This would be gone soon. She wouldn't remember the pattern of her freckles, the way her mismatched eyes held hers, how those lips felt on her own.

"Miss? Are you okay?" She waved a hand in front of her face. "Anybody home?"

The blonde blinked back into the moment. "Sorry, I should leave," Adora replied quickly and ran out of the cafe. Only as she should've been touching the sidewalk, she found herself in her apartment instead. Her former self was slumped over in bed with an annoyed look on her face. She slammed her phone down on the bedside table so hard it was a wonder it didn't break.

"I don't want to see this again," Adora whined to herself as she stood in the corner of her apartment, a helpless spectator to her

own anguish. This memory was the last time she saw Catra, well, the Catra that knew her. *Her Catra.*

The door to the bedroom opened, and there she was. God, she looked even hotter than Adora remembered. She was wearing a short maroon and black jumpsuit that she had paired with black thigh-high boots. Her mane of curly brown hair was side-swept, clearly sweaty from a night of revelry. Make-up that was probably perfectly applied before was smudgy and dark now. Catra propped herself up against the bedroom doorframe, unsteady on her feet.

"Hey, Adora," she said seductively.

"It's three-fifteen. You said you were going to be here around midnight," memory Adora complained from bed. "And you turned off your phone. What were you thinking? I've been worried about you all night."

"You don't have to worry about *me* , 'Dora," she winked and started towards the bed clumsily. "I'm fiiiine. Turned off my phone to save battery is all."

"That doesn't explain why you're here so late," Adora spat back quickly.

"Sorry," she sat down on the edge of the bed. "We went for drinks after the concert, no big deal, dummy. It's called having fun; you remember fun, right?"

They clearly had *many* drinks because she was slurring her words badly at this point, and it only made Adora more annoyed.

Adora huffed. "It's a big deal when you're getting drunk with her, and I'm sitting here worrying about you. We both KNOW she has a crush on you. It's fucked up, Catra. I thought you had more respect for our relationship than this."

"Whoa whoa whoa," Catra turned to her with wild fury and indignation in her eyes. "What are you even saying? You think I'm fucking Scorpia?"

"I think if someone had a crush on me, I wouldn't be out dancing and drinking with them. What if Scorpia thinks you're interested? I would if I were her! You invited her when I have to cancel for work, and got this drunk with her leaving me here waiting on you."

"Fuck you, Adora," Catra got up from the bed and crossed her arms. "Fuck this whole stupid thing if you could think something like that. I'm out of here." She started to rush out of the room. As she got to the door, she looked back at her with an angry scowl. "And for the GOD DAMN record, I only invited her because she's dating the new girl at the cafe. THEY BOTH came."

Adora seemed to only now understand the gravity of what she had set into motion. She thought they'd argue a bit and get over it, but she didn't expect it to turn into a shouting match and the other woman leaving. She got out of bed and started to follow her. Her voice dropped all hints of anger or frustration, and now it was soft and pleading, "Listen, I'm sorry I overreacted. Let's talk about this. Please, stay. I don't want you trying to get home this drunk."

"Stay the fuck away from me," Catra whipped away from her grasp. "I'll get home just fine. I've got tons of girls I can call up and ask to take me home so we can have a good time, right? Because I'm so damn DISRESPECTFUL of our relationship." She turned her gaze over towards the corner where present Adora watched with tears going down her face. She shook her head at her as though she could see her before storming out. The memory Adora collapsed back into bed after the front door slammed.

Adora felt rage bubbling up at her past self, "Chase her, you idiot! We're going to lose her!" Her other self didn't reply or acknowledge her, and she decided to do what she wished she'd done. She sprinted across the small apartment and should've exited in time to at least see Catra down the stairs. Only, she didn't. She was gone.

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When Glimmer and Bow returned to the table, the two women collected themselves from their uproarious laughter. Catra felt more at ease, simply for the reassurance of Adora's affection. Even if these two didn't end up liking her, she got to spend the evening with Adora either way. Seemed like a win.

"Bad news," Bow cleared his throat before starting his lie, "I don't think there's any kind of fix right now."

"Shit," Catra mumbled as she put her phone away. "That's my luck. At least I didn't lose any school stuff."

"You're in school? We just all graduated last year," Glimmer tried to sound as casual as possible. "What are you studying?"

"I would've graduated last year too, but I took a gap year before starting college to find myself or whatever. Such a cliche, I know. I'm studying game theory. Finishing up in May," she realized when saying this it was also the first time her date was hearing it too. They had really skipped a lot of the basic getting-to-know-you stuff and went right into talking...and other things... as though they'd known each other for years.

"Like video games?" Adora smiled and tried to pretend she had any idea what game theory meant.

"Not exactly," she laughed. "It's the game of strategy. You can apply it to a lot of stuff — economics, politics, business, et cetera."

"Game theory is really cool. You can use it to predict what someone might do in response to someone else's decision, right?" Bow raised an eyebrow and got kicked under the table by Glimmer.

"A fellow nerd," Catra smirked in appreciation and offered a high five that he returned. "That's a part of it. Honestly, makes my social life kind of confusing sometimes."

"Can you guess what I'm going to do yet," Adora asked in a flirty way, but Catra turned to analyze her with an earnest look on her face. She felt her cheeks burning as those gold and blue eyes took her in.

She leaned into her space and whispered "I'd tell you, but it doesn't make for appropriate dinner conversation in front of your friends."

Adora's heart skipped, but she did the best to quell the heated reaction she wanted to have. Mercifully, the waiter showed up with both Glimmer's gigantic margarita and the appetizers they had ordered. The rest of the double date went smoothly from there. They ate, drank, and settled into their regular rhythm. Slowly but surely, Catra no longer felt self-conscious. Even 'Sparkles,' as she decided to name Glimmer, made her laugh and teamed up with her on teasing Adora.

While Adora and Glimmer were finishing up their meals, Catra looked at Bow with excitement lit up in her eyes, "Hey, nerd, wanna play a quick game or two? I noticed they have a few retro machines in the next room."

"Only if you don't mind when I beat you," he said confidently. "As you...um, you *all* know, I am the arcade champion."

"We'll see about that," she hopped up from her stool and gave Adora a quick kiss. "I'm sorry, gotta defend my honor."

Once they were out of earshot, the blonde looked at Glimmer hopefully, "She's great, right?"

"Yeah, she fits in perfectly." Glimmer nodded dumbly, her frustration with the weird predicament at least dulled by the alcohol. "You two really seem to hit it off. How did you meet exactly?"

"It's so weird! It's like… fate or something! Yesterday, I was on my way to work, and I felt so weird."

"Uh-huh," she narrowed her eyes and focused on keeping her mouth shut.

"I saw the switch to Eternia Beach, and I had to get off the train and go. Next thing you know, I'm in this diner, and she's there looking so damn hot, and we exchange looks. And she's there at the stop when I'm leaving… and then she sits with me and teaches me about cats! Did you know about cats? I never ever knew a cat, but now I know Melog, and he loves me," Adora's tipsy rambling continued as she detailed everything to Glimmer.

"You've never skipped work in your life," was Glimmer's first response after she finally had a chance to say something.

"I KNOW, right?! If I hadn't, who knows, we might never have met," Adora looked wistfully back towards where Catra and Bow had disappeared. "I'm so glad we met."

Meanwhile, Bow and Catra were in the middle of taking turns on one of the racing arcade games. Catra was down a win already, but she wasn't going to give up. She stood behind him, trying her best to heckle him out of concentration, but it wasn't working. "Told ya, I'm the champ," he looked back at her with a childish grin.

"Only because all the fighting games are taken right now," she taunted back. "I always kick your ass at those."

Bow almost didn't register it, almost didn't remember this was supposed to be the first time they'd played anything together. He let go of the steering wheel and turned as he stared up at her in hopeful confusion. Her eyes met his for a moment before her head dropped, and she began grabbing her hair and pulling while she cried out in pain.

"It's okay, you're okay, buddy," Bow said comfortingly as he got up and put his hands on her shoulders. "Catra, can you look at me? Do you know who I am?"

Catra released her head and met eyes with him again. She stared at him unblinking, her pupils blown. "Of course, I know who you are, Bow. What the fuck is happening?" she asked shakily, running a hand through her hair again. "Why is my--"

Suddenly, her eyes drifted closed, and she started to slump as though she might pass out. Bow braced for her to do so, but instead, she popped back up and seemed fine again. "Whoa, sorry about that. Fucking thunderclap headaches. I've had them all week," she rubbed her temples as she pulled back from him. "Drinking and staring at blinking lights was probably not a good idea, huh?"

"Yeah, not a great combo," he tried to stay more neutral despite every part of him wanting to investigate.

"Maybe we can convince those two to make the second double date at a real arcade or something. *Then* we'll see I'm the real champ." Catra smiled and started back over towards the table where they'd left the other women.

Bow followed along behind her, somehow more bewildered than he already was. He smiled at Glimmer and made his eyes large before he said, "Glim, don't you have that appointment in the morning? We probably should get going."

"Oh, yeah! My appointment.. with the doctor," Glimmer stammered and giggled. "See you two later. Don't get into more trouble, okay? This is *stressful*."

Catra and Adora didn't question what she was going on about, as much as sober Bow was concerned. Instead, they hopped up and exchanged hugs with the other couple before they left.

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"What's up," a groggy male voice answered the phone finally. "You okay?"

"No," Catra whimpered quietly between sniffles. "Need to go home. Please."

"I've got you; it'll be okay," Bow replied and then whispered something to what she figured was to his fiancé.

She could hear the sound of the bed squeaking and other rustlings as Bow was getting up. It was closer to four than three in the morning at this point. In a world where she wasn't already full of emotional anguish and drunken confusion, she'd have more space for feeling guilty about making her friend get up in the middle of the night. She started crying again in hard, gasping sobs that she tried to muffle by curling her body further into herself. The last thing she needed was a nosy neighbor coming out to see who was crying on the floor of their apartment lobby. Hell, she didn't even live here.

"Stay calm; I'm on my way. Tell me where I'm going."

"Adora's, can't stay." She felt like a child calling a parent to come to rescue them. "Messed up, real bad."

"Got it. I'll be there soon. Let's stay on the line, so we know we've got each other, okay? You don't have to talk."

"Thanks, Bow." She put the phone on speakerphone and sat it on the cold tile floor below her.

While realistically, the drive from Glimmer and Bow's place was only around ten minutes, it seemed more like ten hours. The more time dragged on, the worse she felt. She was a helpless passenger on a ship in the middle of a storm — everything was undulating: the floor, the walls, her stomach, and her mind. She lost the only thing she wanted to anchor herself to— Adora.

She was supposed to always see the best in her, but that was clearly a lie now if she could imagine a world where Catra would ever cheat on her. Cheating on *Adora*? She was the only person she had ever loved, ever truly wanted that way. Yet, no one knew her better than Adora, so… maybe she was right. Maybe Catra

was a time bomb waiting to explode and ruin everything in their relationship…

She was brought out of her self-pity and doubt by the door of the lobby opening. Soft steps toward her and a gentle hand on her back followed.

"Hey buddy," Bow said softly. "Can you walk?"

"I think so," she answered quietly as she tried to stand. Her feet faltered, but Bow managed to catch her and she shifted to lean some of her weight on him as they left.

Once they were both buckled up safely in the car, he cautiously tried to assess the situation. "Do you want to go back to your place? If not, there's always the guest room at ours. We got new sheets! Very cozy."

"Home," she answered as she laid her head on the side of the door. "Cause Melog."

"Right! Can't forget little buddy." He glanced over at her and frowned. "Do you want to talk about what's going on?"

"She doesn't trust me, probably hates me now," she replied. Her voice was slurred, but Bow understood all the same. "Thinks I wanna fuck *Scorpia*. Why, Bow? What... I never would… never would do that to her."

"I know you wouldn't," Bow confirmed, reaching over to pat her shoulder. "I'm sure she does too. We all say things we don't mean when we're upset, right?"

"Guess so," she sounded unconvinced as she slunk down further.

The rest of the drive to her place was quiet. She had started to drift in and out of sleep. One time was long enough that she swore she heard Adora's voice saying she loved her, but then Catra opened her eyes and faced cold reality. Bow pulled up to her apartment complex and came around to her side. She stumbled

out of the car, but once again, he was there to keep her from smashing her face. God, she hadn't overdone it drinking this bad in a long time. Everything about this night was mortifyingly embarrassing.

"How about I give you a lift," Bow offered. "Might be safer than trying to get yourself up the stairs."

"Okay." She was in no position to refuse. With that, he picked her up in a gentle bridal carry. "This is how Adora carries me.. when.. when I..." She started crying again with short sobs.

Once they got inside, Bow told her to go to bed, and he went about taking care of Melog. Catra had already planned on not being back for the evening, but Bow made sure he would be set up for breakfast. Hopefully, that meant the cat wouldn't be trying to wake up his mother before she was mostly human again. That taken care of, he filled one of her large gym water bottles and brought it to her bedside. She was snuggled up in bed, cuddling one of her pillows.

"Did you take all of your meds already?" He asked as he put the water down.

"No," she said, muffled into the pillow before she turned to look up at him. "Bathroom."

After figuring out what she needed to take, he played nurse for her. "I'm so sorry," Catra whined after swallowing her last pill. Her voice was shaking. "So, so sorry. I shouldn't need you to do this stuff for me. I'm such a fuck up."

"Absolutely not. You're the smartest person I know. And this is what friends are for. You did this for me at the beach last summer, remember? I don't think I can drink another Pina Colada ever again. I'm glad I can return the favor."

"You're my best, best friend, Bow." She pulled him into a tight hug. "What if she doesn't want me anymore? Gonna lose you guys too."

He hugged her back for a moment. "She loves you, Catra, and you're always going to be my friend no matter what."

"But.. this.. was the worst fight. I don't like that Adora thinks that about me. Want her to think I'm good."

"Hey, come on, you know she doesn't really think anything bad about you," Bow tried to stay positive. "Every couple has fights. Glimmer and I have fights. Remember that time we almost broke up over the dishes?"

Catra giggled at the memory despite her gloomy mood, "Yeah. Sparkles was *piiiisssssed."*

"We both were, but all we needed to do was talk, right? It wasn't about the dishes." She nodded. "We talked, and now what's happening in June?"

"I get to wear a nice suit," she smirked.

"That's right, buddy, because you're my best man at our wedding that's still happening even though we had a big fight."

"But *Adora* never gets mad at me, Bow, never ever, and if she's this mad and she said those things, it follows that --" he cut her off.

"Quit that. Your theory brain is too drunk to predict what's going to happen. All you need to do is drink some more water and sleep."

"Okay," she downed some more water and collapsed back into the bed.

Melog, who had been watching from the floor, decided this was his moment and jumped on top of her. She reached for him and held the cat to her chest like a stuffed animal, not that he minded. He was all purrs and comfort. Bow sat with them for a while longer to make sure that she wouldn't get sick and stayed calm.

"Alright, everybody, unless you need me to stay longer, I'm going to lock up and head home. Are we good with that?" She nodded before resting her chin on top of Melog's head. "Call or text if you need anything at all. That's what I'm here for."

That was the last thing that Catra vaguely remembered before waking up to slamming knocks on her front door. Everything hurt now. Her eyelids felt like sandpaper, her stomach was rolling, and the world hadn't gotten the memo that it was supposed to stop spinning if Adora didn't like her anymore. She groaned and picked up the water bottle, chugging it down. She managed to make it to her feet, and as she approached the door, she could hear a voice on the other side.

"Catra! Hello? Are you there?" Her favorite voice called.

She placed her hand on the door and felt her heart aching. All she wanted to do was throw the door open and leap into her girlfriend's arms. Then, her memory caught up with her. She wasn't only sad about what happened; she was angry and disillusioned too. The leftover poison from the night before was churning through her veins, and the pain of the hangover pulsed. "Go away, ADORA." she growled.

"I only wanted to check if you were okay," Adora yelled back.

"I'll be fine when you GO AWAY! You're disturbing me and all the hot girls I brought home to fuck!"

"Quit being so IMMATURE!" Adora scolded her. Oh, she hated that.

Catra was officially not doing this right now. Lest Adora think to use her spare key, she put the deadbolt on and walked away. She started to feed Melog but noticed that Bow had made sure he was already well set up. With that, she went back into her bedroom and slammed the door behind her. She hoped the noise carried. Eventually, Adora must have given up because there was only silence now.

Catra laid in bed all day, only getting up for the bare necessities. She missed an entire day of classes and a work shift. At least the latter, she could get covered with a quick text to Scorpia and Perfuma. She couldn't bring herself to care enough about the former. Everything was fucking falling apart anyway.

Adora had stopped reaching out by the second day of silence. The last text she had sent was, "I get it, you need space. I can do that." Catra didn't want space; she wanted the exact opposite. Only, she was terrified. She felt like if she allowed herself to see Adora... then she'd know that it really was over. That their relationship had been too good to be true.

Day three of languishing in bed, she got an email from one of her professors that was CC'd to her graduation advisor. She had missed a couple of deadlines and a test. Not a great week to be skipping every day. If this kept up, it was going to be nearly impossible for her to pass. Her advisor emailed her separately and asked her to call immediately. She groaned, sat up in bed, and decided to try to sort this out. She didn't work for four years to mess up in the last few months.

"Hello, Dr. Hordak? This is Catra," she cleared her throat and tried to sound professional. "You asked me to call you?"

"Yes, Ms. Catra, thank you for returning my request. It seems as though you're off track."

"I've been going through something personal that's impacting my mental health."

"Ah, I see." She heard the shuffling of papers. "I hate to hear that. Your department says you are a valuable asset to their program. The professor who contacted me was hoping you'd consider graduate school. Seems as though you're a likely candidate for a scholarship and a TA position."

She didn't know how to process that. Sure, she had filled out an application for their graduate program, but it wasn't submitted yet

despite her better intentions. Everything really was off track lately. Maybe Adora could tell she was on her way to disaster...

"What I'm saying is-- a mind like yours is a terrible thing to waste, yes?"

"I understand. I'm really having a hard time right now, but I know I shouldn't let my personal life distract me. I'll be back in class soon."

"I'd like to send you some information about a program that my brother runs. I have found it has been quite helpful for many of my students who have ended up in similar situations. They all have been able to graduate right on time, even better than they were before."

That sounded appealing. Maybe it was some kind of tutorial that would allow her to make up the missed time in class? Sure, Catra never needed tutoring in her life, but if it got her back in good standing when she was ready, that would be worth it. "Yes, please. That would be great, thank you."

"Wonderful, I am happy to hear you are willing to do whatever it takes. We shouldn't let our pain hold us back from our greatness. I will send you everything you need. If you have any questions, don't hesitate to reach out. Farewell, Ms. Catra."

Chapter End Notes

> As always, please let me know what you think! This fic hurts in a lot of ways, but I'm enthused about where I have to go with it.
>
> Also I believe in Catra and Bow best-friendship, and it's the default in all my AUs. I love writing their nerdy friendship.

Try Your Best

Chapter Summary

> A missed call has never meant so much. Adora and Catra make plans. Glimmer starts trying to piece together the truth.

Chapter Notes

> It's worth noting that while I have named them both Dr. Hordak, I do imagine one of them filling the "Horde Prime" role. I didn't want to give them different 'last' names (as I'm using Hordak in this sense) since they're brothers. Which is which? Let's find out.
>
> It's also worth noting that Entrapta is her first name, and she prefers using it with her Dr. title as opposed to her last name that I've definitely planned and exists... for sure...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra sat in the waiting room tapping her foot on the tile floor while trying to navigate all of the forms she had been given to fill out. Her advisor had emailed her the program's website to review before coming. It turned out to decidedly not be a tutoring center, but instead, offered some kind of unusual therapy that involved looking at brain scans. Pretty fucking weird, if you asked her, but everything she read seemed legit.

Dr. Hordak promised that he had gotten her professors to agree that doing this would allow her absences to be excused and restore her grades back to the A's they were before her 'unfortunate situation' as he had delicately put it. Plus, it seemed like this could be really good for her. The success stories she read promised she would communicate and control her emotions better after treatment. If this meant she could be a better version of herself, well, fuck it, she could admit she had some things to work on. Certainly seemed more productive than what she had been doing since the fight.

Step one: that morning, she had bundled up all of the random Adora-related items in her home in a tote. The instructions said she needed to bring all items related to the "inciting person or event." When she got out of the taxi, she thought she was in the wrong place at first. The name on the door didn't match the one on the website she'd been sent: Prime Healing online versus Prime Enterprises in person. Still, it listed Dr. Hordak's name, and once she got the nerve to enter, the peppy receptionist assured her she was in the right place. Thus, here she sat. Filling out forms and listing what felt like a *ridiculous* amount of contact information for people in her life.

Finally, the other Dr. Hordak came and called her back to join him in the office. An enthusiastic woman in a lab coat collected her tote along the way. "Hey, pigtails! Be careful with that," she admonished the other woman as she was skipping along the hall. "There's fragile stuff in there. I didn't have time to pack it well." The pink-haired doctor looked at her with a confused expression and then complied with the request. Once she was in the doctor's office, she analyzed the man who had led her in. He seemed every bit as inscrutable as his brother.

"From the records I've received, it sounds like you are interested in getting your life back on track after an unfortunate turn of personal events. Is this correct, Ms. Catra?"

"Yeah, that pretty much sums it up. I've been on meds for my mental health for a long time now, and they usually do the job." She awkwardly shifted in the uncomfortable chair. Catra anticipated this whole thing entailed talking about what she considered private, but it didn't make it any easier.

"But this event with," he looked down at the documentation she had filled out, "Adora? That conflict was triggering for you, made it difficult to come back to peace?"

"Yeah, it really fucked with my head. I haven't been taking care of myself, too, which made things worse. It's weird. Like, right now, I know it wasn't even that big of a fight. More stupid than

anything. The problem is, I can't get myself to believe that for long. I spiral, and it shuts me down."

"You have my sympathies, but you are an excellent candidate for the procedure we offer. It should help give you a bit of a reset if you will. We can help you feel more at peace and able to move on from this even better than it was before."

"That's what your brother said." She sighed as her head hung low and stared at her hands. "Adora and I can move past this. I just need to make myself talk about it with her. I'm more worried about being able to finish school this semester. My scholarships won't cover summer sessions, and he promised me that this would get everything in the last week excused. If not, it'll set me back. Then I'm also applying to grad school. It's a whole fucking mess."

"Of course," he smiled and made some notes on the papers. "He informed me of what an excellent student you are, top of your program, so much potential. It would be a shame to let such emotions get in the way of your success. Shall we discuss what we can do to help you?" She nodded back defeatedly. "The first thing we'll do is map your brain using the items you brought. This will help us understand where these less desirable emotions are rooted, and our one-of-a-kind technology will allow us to correct the source of your pain."

"Wait what," Catra raised an eyebrow. "Like brain surgery or something?"

"Something akin to that, but it's very minor. In fact, we could have the whole process done here in our facility today."

Catra sat staring at the man for a long time, trying to piece everything together. Everything she had read and heard gave her the impression this was some new-age bullshit. These people were actually going to do something to her brain?

"I'm going to have to think about this. I guess I didn't realize it was that big of a process."

"Ms. Catra, please do not worry. It won't hurt at all. You read the website my brother sent you, yes? All those lost souls we were able to help?"

"Yeah, it sounded like this was some new therapy or medication. It never said these were stories about people who got their brains fucked with."

He laughed, and the sound of it made her skin crawl. "That is certainly a unique way to put it. I'm afraid delaying is not possible based on your goals. Our schedule is booked solid for months, and I was only able to take you today as a favor to my dear brother."

Her mind was rushing a million places. She couldn't think with the unusual doctor staring at her. "Listen, I appreciate that and all, but can I get ten minutes to process this and come back with my decision?"

"Be my guest, Ms. Catra. We'll go ahead and prepare in hopes that you will see this is the best opportunity for you."

She got up from the chair and made her way through the business back out to the sidewalk. The receptionist said something to her, but she had no idea what. While she paced outside of the strip mall, Catra tried to focus on her breathing and make her hands stop shaking. She wondered if it was from anxiety or that she hadn't eaten anything today. Probably a combination of both.

Finally, she took her phone out of her pocket called the only person she could talk to about something like this. After waiting through several rings, the phone went to voicemail. He was at work, of course. She started the message, "Hey, Bow. Give me a call back when you can. I'm about to do something that might be really stupid; wanted to see what you thought. Also, I know all

this wedding planning shit's keeping you busy, but don't forget Valentine's Day. It will be the dishes all over again if you don't do something for Sparkles. Get a res at that new hipster place on Elm; she won't stop liking their posts. Anyway, talk to you later, buddy." After waiting for a few more minutes without a callback, she figured she was done stalling. Surely this couldn't be dangerous or bad if her university directed her here, right? She thought about texting Adora to set up a time to talk after, but the idea made her chest tighter. She decided it might be better to try after she was "healed."

"Be honest, how'd I do," Catra asked after the other couple disappeared from the restaurant.

"You were amazing," she confirmed happily. "Bow definitely loved you, and you and Glimmer were too funny together."

"Thanks," she gave a sigh of relief. "Kinda intimidating to meet the best friends after day one, but I really like them."

"When do I get to meet your best friends, hmm? I wonder if they'll like me as much as mine do you."

Catra scrunched up her face and frowned. "I actually don't have anyone I'd call a best friend. I have friends at work; we're not super close. At school, I'm laser-focused on what I'm doing. I don't really take the time to get to know people or whatever."

"I'm really honored that you're taking the time to get to know me," Adora smirked, trying to lighten the mood again.

"Maybe I've been saving up all my time for you. I guess I'll spare some for your friends too. They are pretty entertaining."

"Thanks," Adora smiled as she leaned over and brought them into a kiss so heated she felt a little self-conscious about doing it in public. She pulled away, and they stared back at each other with

the same lovesick, hungry look on their faces. "Speaking of entertaining... would you want to stay at my place tonight?"

"Very smooth, dummy," Catra laughed. "Yeah, I'd love to. Is it okay if we stop off by my place to check on Melog and so I can grab a couple things for tomorrow?"

"If I can come up to hug him," she really was looking forward to seeing this fascinating creature again.

"Definitely, you're all he's talked about. Meow-meow, Adora this. Mew mrow, Adora that." With that, they hopped up and headed out together hand-in-hand.

"Hey, Adora? Earth to dummy!" Catra was waving her hands dramatically in front of her girlfriend's face. "Is your brain frozen? Need more cocoa?"

Adora blinked a few times, and as she realized what was happening, she couldn't help but smile. This was a much sweeter memory than the last. "I'm okay," she cooed and snuggled closer on the couch. They were all wrapped up in a blanket with Melog sleeping on their laps. After letting herself soak in the warmth, she couldn't hold back her emotions any longer, "Catra?"

"Yes, dummy? Do you need me to warm you up some more? Hmm?" She brushed her lips against the side of the blonde's neck as she spoke.

"I love you. I love you more than I even knew I could love someone. God, Catra, I'm so sorry for everything." Her voice began breaking as she tried to keep herself from sobbing. "I can't believe I'm losing you. This is all going to be gone."

"Whoa, calm down, silly. You're never going to lose me." Catra wrapped her arms around her and squeezed as she kissed the side of her face, "Sure, smashing a snowball on my head after I

just straightened my hair was pretty low, but I can find it in my heart to forgive you."

"No, it's not that," Adora pulled her into her lap and held her face in her hands. Catra was looking at her like she had lost her mind. "We had a big fight. I was so awful to you, and it made you do something stupid, and I can't take it back."

"Adora, breathe. Please?" She nodded. "We have *never* had a big fight. Are you feeling okay? You're not making any sense."

"We haven't, but we *will*. In a couple of weeks--"

Catra cut her off with a smirk, "You're telling the future now?"

"No, it's that.... this is the past. It's a memory; it's not even real, Catra. As much as I want it to be, it's not."

"Okay, I don't know about you, but I feel pretty fucking real. My ass hurts from where I slipped on the sidewalk. Isn't that what they say 'pinch me' for?" She combed her hands through her long blonde hair soothingly. Adora *could* feel it. "Why don't you tell me what you think is happening or will happen or whatever else is going on in that beautiful brain of yours?"

Adora sniffled, burying her face in her shoulder, "The fight started because I was mad at you for drinking with Scorpia. I accused you of leading her on, disrespecting me."

"That's ridiculous, Adora. Maybe even more ridiculous than you claiming that you know the future. I would <u>never</u> do something like that to you. I hate that you'd even think that."

"I know. Fuck, I know," she whined. She wished she hadn't said anything and that they could go back to cuddling happily. But... she started this. Memory Catra deserved answers as much as the real one had. "I was mad and jealous. I wasn't thinking."

"Okay, so that's settled. What stupid thing did *I* in your alternate reality do because *you're* an idiot?"

"You erased me from your memories."

"That's some sci-fi shit, Adora. Melog, I think we're going to have to call in Glimmer and Bow. We need sane back-up."

Without warning, the room began to shift and change. Catra's apartment was popping out of existence, and snow started falling into the room. She gave a squeaky, scared cry and tightened her grip on Adora. Suddenly, they were on the couch still, but it was in the middle of the snow-covered street.

"What the fuck was that?! How did we get here?! Were there drugs in that cocoa?" Catra was panicking now, eyes wildly darting around the scene. "Where's Melog?! He was right here with us."

"Catra," Adora leaned forward, tears flowing down her cold cheeks, and pressed their foreheads together. "I made it worse. When I found out I couldn't fix you, I decided to erase you too. I'm so sorry. I wish I could stop it; I don't want this anymore. I don't think I ever did. I didn't think it through."

"Of course, you didn't think; you're such an idiot," Catra was crying now too, but managed a determined smile. "We can fix this. Fuck, I know I can game this out. I just need a minute. How does this work? What did they tell you?"

"They made a map of my memories. It's like they're moving backward through our time together and deleting you."

"Okay, okay." Catra hummed to herself and got up from the couch, grabbing Adora's hand. "Take me somewhere they didn't map--- a time and place before you knew me. Maybe I can hide there, and you'll remember when you wake up? And then you can tell real me that I'm an idiot for once."

"Catra, I don't think that's how this works," Adora whined, "It's all my fault. It's over. There's nothing we can do."

"You can't give up. This is our only chance. We can do this; all we need to do is stay together. Okay? Now focus for me, please.

Where don't I belong? Let's go there fucking fast because," she gestured at the street ahead, which was becoming blurry, "I'm about to get scrubbed out of here."

"This place has the most annoying waiting message of all time," Glimmer complained as she watched Bow getting ready for work. "I think I'm being hypnotized!" She swapped to speakerphone to make her point.

A haunting male voice came through the speaker: "Rejoice, broken-hearted and lost souls, Prime Enterprises is here for you. You need no longer fear, for your mind will be allowed to share in a renewed, peaceful world. Please continue to hold. No wait will be better rewarded. There is no darkness we cannot pierce with our healing light."

"Yeah, that's really creepy," Bow sighed. "Have you gotten to talk to someone yet?"

"The receptionist, but he wouldn't tell me anything. This place is sketchy, Bow. I was suspicious before, but this message?" It continued to drone behind her, on and on, with peaceful music playing behind. "It feels super manipulative, right? If I was going through an emotional breakdown, I'd be like, sign me up!"

Bow was standing in front of their mirror, straightening his shirt. She could see him frown at his reflection, but before he had a chance to explain his thoughts, someone picked up. "Hello, this is Dr. Entrapta."

Glimmer decided to dial back the frustration she was feeling in her response. "Hi. I was hoping you might be able to answer some questions for me. Two of my friends, Catra and Adora, received treatments from your practice."

"I apologize, but I am restricted from giving personal medical history. It would be unethical."

"I thought that you all would like to know that you screwed up! So, unless you want me talking to the state medical board instead, someone needs to answer some questions for me."

"Something malfunctioned? That is fascinating and distressing." She could hear furious typing and clicking. "While there were some anomalies, the extraction of Adora and Relationship as well as Catra and Relationship was successful. I'm afraid that's all I can confirm."

"I can promise you it wasn't successful! If you can't tell me anything else, send me to someone who can."

"I'll send you over to Dr. Hordak; I am positive he'll know what to do. I will continue reviewing the data as well."

One ring and then that damn holding message again. Glimmer groaned as she slumped against the bed.

"Any luck?" Bow asked as he came to sit with her.

"This Dr. Entrapta acted like she couldn't tell me anything. Now she's put me through to a Dr. Hordak. Total runaround! If he doesn't give me answers, I swear..."

Bow looked at the clock on the wall with another deep frown, "I'm going to be late for work. Text me if you figure out something, okay? I love you," he punctuated by leaning down to kiss her tenderly. "I know you're off today, but promise me you won't go over there."

"Not without you, promise. I love you too," she confirmed and sat back up again to watch her fiance leave with his shoulders slumped and looking drained. She hated to see him so down. "Have I told you lately how cute your butt is?" That earned a laugh, and he turned back to wink at her.

After another long wait on hold, she wondered if they were hoping she'd hang up. Tough luck, Prime Assholes, she thought. Glimmer had time today. She brought her phone and the creepy

message along with her as she worked on her typical off-day errands.

Finally, after the one-thousandth iteration of the message, someone answered on the other line again. "Hello. This is Dr. Hordak. I've been informed that you have some concerns about two of our patients."

"Yes, Catra and Adora. You treated them both in the last week. I'm Glimmer. They both listed me as a contact."

"I do recall. While it is still early in Ms. Adora's recovery, it seems Ms. Catra is thriving again. What is troubling you?"

"Many things, actually. One, you should know that whatever you're doing there isn't reliable. Catra and Adora met again on their own and are together anyway. I, for one, think that's a good thing. I don't know what you did to convince Catra to do this in the first place and start this whole mess."

"That is a very accusatory statement, Ms. Glimmer. I can assure you that Ms. Catra came to us of her own volition. She was well informed of the risks and what the end result would be."

"I'll have to ask her about it when she gets her memories back, and we'll see if she reports the same thing."

"That is quite impossible. While it is unusual that your friends have found one another again, it does not change the fact that our procedures here are 100% effective. Neither young woman will recall anything about our practice or her very voluntary procedures. Is there anything else I can help you with, or are you merely interested in attacking our practice?"

"Trust me, I have not BEGUN to attack your practice, and when I do, the whole thing will be in boxes on the street. What I want to know is if there is anything health-wise I should be worried about for them interacting like this?"

"This could be a concern. It is difficult to know without examining them. If I were in your position, I would discourage the relationship from progressing further while it is still in the early stages."

"That is not an option. I am not going to manipulate my friends."

"Then, I have nothing else to suggest to you, Ms. Glimmer. I hope that my former patients will still thrive as was intended. Farewell."

With that, the phone line went dead.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed/hurt (good hurt?)/are intrigued? I feel all the emotions while writing and reading back over this one. Let me know what you think! Thanks for reading!

If you'd like to chat with me about my stories on social or other catradora brainrot (as the youth say), I am:
motherofchimeras -- tumblr and Instagram
momofchimeras - Twitter

Wash and Repeat

Chapter Summary

> Catra experiences changes, and is given an opportunity that feels too good to be true. Glimmer and Bow continue to try to hold things together.

"I can't think of anything without you," Adora whined as she was being dragged down the snowy street by her girlfriend. The world behind them was continuing to blur and fade.

"Real sweet, dummy, but that's not true. Come on. This is your brain. You're in charge here," Catra shouted and pulled them even faster.

"You're right. I can do this," Adora closed her eyes and focused as hard as she could. Before she even opened them, she could tell she was somewhere new. The chill of the wind outside was replaced by muggy, heavy air. Did it work? She was almost too scared to find out.

"Holy shit," she heard Catra say. "Who am I?"

Finally, she allowed herself to open her eyes, and her jaw dropped as she took in her girlfriend's new form. Catra, all six feet of her, was staring at herself in the mirrors of Adora's college locker room.

"Oh my god," Adora laughed. "You're supposed to be Elyse, I think. We played rugby together my freshman year of college, and um," she scratched at the back of her head. It felt strange; her hair was much shorter in this version of herself. "She and I had a fling."

"Damn, 'Dora, good for you. This chick was a beast," Catra mused to herself while flexing her new muscles and admiring the hybrid appearance of herself and this 'Elyse.' Her hair was styled into a curly mohawk, and she was wearing only a sports bra and shorts.

Her abs put even Adora's to shame. "I have to say, this is a good look for me. What do you think?" She turned around and winked before sauntering over to the blonde.

"Every look is hot on you," Adora said smoothly. She could feel her cheeks getting red as she ran her eyes up and down the other woman's body.

"Thanks," Catra laughed and continued to move into her space until she had Adora backed against the lockers. "And here I thought being bigger than you was an impossible fantasy." With that, she bent down and lifted her chin into a kiss.

Adora knew she should probably stay focused on the task at hand of saving the memory of the love of her life. Still, she couldn't help herself as she ran her hands over the exquisite muscles that were now a part of the body towering over her. Hitting the gym had always been a part of her and Catra's couple routines, but getting buff was never a goal for her girlfriend.

"Do you really think this will work," Adora managed to ask, trying desperately to keep some level of her wits about her. "We can hide you here?"

"We can certainly try," Catra moved her new, larger hands down to Adora’s ass and lifted. She reacted with a gasp but then wrapped her legs around her torso to steady herself. "Might as well have fun while we do, right?"

"Dr. Hordak," Entrapta called from the portable desk she had set up by the patient's bed. She was staring at her laptop screen and trying to make sense of the errors she was seeing. "I believe I'm going to need your assistance. It's happening again."

"As I expected," he sighed and got up from the armchair where he was sitting and reading. "So predictable, young love."

"It is highly unusual," she noted as she stepped away from the computer and let him take a look. She pulled out her pocket recorder and began making verbal notes. "It's as though her subconscious is fighting the procedure, as I suspected with subject Catra. But why would that happen? They both asked for this to be done. Perhaps we should stop and wake her to discuss it? I know you didn't want to before--"

"Emotional attachment can be quite limiting," Dr. Hordak cut her off coldly as he examined the live feed of brain activity. "It does not matter what this Adora believes she wants now. We have an obligation to fulfill her original request."

"Got it," she nodded and then pointed at the map. "Ooh! I see a spike right here. How fascinating. This is far from where we have mapped."

As Catra walked into Adora's apartment for the first time, she looked around at the generally blank space and frowned. "Yep, you definitely need me. You might be built like a warrior, but the spartan decor look is too depressing."

"You think?" The blonde laughed as she locked the door behind them. "I guess it doesn't look too different from when I moved in. I don't know why I've never decorated."

"Maybe you needed a muse like me."

"That is definitely it. I'd like to see how you could inspire me in the bedroom," she winked and gave a smug smile.

"You look entirely too proud of that line," Catra laughed to herself before she leaned into the other woman's ear as she whispered, "But if inspiration’s what you’re looking for, Princess, this muse can provide."

With that motivation, Adora wasted no time grabbing her hand and guiding her to her bedroom. Once inside, they looked at each

other with a combination of nerves and desire.

"So, what do you want tonight," Catra asked as she backed up towards the blonde's bed and sat down.

"Um, well," her face was red again.

"I can't believe you're the one that keeps coming on to me, and then you get all nervous when it's time to do something about it," she gave a coy smile as she watched her shift awkwardly on her feet.

"I am not," Adora said petulantly as she stepped forward till she was standing in front of the other woman. "I want to fuck that grin off your face."

"Do it then," she challenged with a wink.

Catra woke up with Adora's arms around her as they spooned in her small bed. She couldn't remember the last time she felt so content. It was strange how everything between them was progressing so fast, but she chalked it up to a little bit of fate mixed with being old enough to know what they wanted. And god... did she want Adora. It was practically all she had thought about since she saw her at the beach. Her dreams the last two nights were filled with the two of them, and they weren't even strictly sexual. Instead, they were everything from boringly domestic to her mind slotting Adora into moments from her own life in the last few years.

She didn't want to wake up the blonde, but she did need to check the time. She wiggled an arm out and grabbed for her phone. Damn, 6AM, she really ought to be getting up if she was going to make it to the cafe on time.

"Hey Adora," she said quietly as not to scare her. "I've gotta start getting ready. Is it okay if I use your shower?"

"Course," she mumbled sleepily as she let her go. "Fucked you in there."

"Guess someone wakes up horny," Catra laughed as she kissed her forehead. "Unless I missed it, we haven't done that *yet* ."

"Sorry," Adora rubbed her eyes and yawned. "I guess I dreamed that. Is that embarrassing?"

"More like hot, dummy. And if I wasn't in a hurry, I'd want to make it a reality." Catra finally dragged herself out of bed. "Oh hey, before I forget. Will you give me Bow's number? I've finally got someone I can text all my nerdy shit to."

"Oh sure," Adora sat up and grabbed her own. "I'll just add you to our group chat."

"I'm honored to join the Best Friend Squad."

"How'd you know that's what we call it?" Adora raised an eyebrow as she finished making the update.

"Huh. I don't know," Catra paused and thought for a moment. She hadn't even questioned it when the words came out of her mouth. "I'm sure one of you said it last night. Too lame to forget."

After finally departing and subsequently surviving another morning slinging coffee, Catra was ready for her usual Saturday afternoon routine of doing laundry. As she walked down the sidewalk, she wondered if Adora had machines in her unit. Would it be too needy to ask if she could do her laundry there to see her again? Probably, she decided. She texted anyway.

Catra : Hey, Adora. This might be weird, but do you have laundry machines?

Adora: Hi you :) Sadly, no! I usually go to Glimmer and Bow's place. Today's my laundry day too. Want to join me? I've got a small load, I'm sure they won't mind.

Catra: You don't have to do that.

Too late.

[Best Friend Squad Group Chat]

Adora: Hey! Is it okay Catra comes with me for laundry today?

Glimmer: Sure! We'll make a girls' day of it. Bow had to do an extra day at work.

Catra: What do your girls' days entail?

Glimmer: Wine and bad reality tv.

Catra: I'm in. Thanks.

Glimmer: I'll send you the address.

Once she walked in the door, Melog happily circled her feet. After giving him a hug, she sat down at her computer to make a to-do list for herself for school tasks that needed to be done before Monday as well. When she pulled up her university email, she was surprised to see that she already had another email from her advisor. Their meeting on Thursday had gone well and confirmed that she was on her way to graduating with honors in May. She expected that she wouldn't be hearing from him again. She opened it up and read while stroking Melog, who had hopped up into her lap:

SUBJECT : Important Update, Read ASAP

Body Text : Ms. Catra, it was a pleasure speaking with you this week about your progress towards your graduation in May. As we discussed, I know you are very interested in attending graduate school with us in the fall. Since our meeting, I have learned of a unique opportunity to grant you a full scholarship and provide additional funds for all living expenses starting in June. Please call at your earliest opportunity, as this is a limited-time offer.

Regards,

Dr. Hordak

"Hot damn, Melog," she said happily as she finished the email and snuggled the cat closer. "I could quit work. Everything's coming up Catra this week."

"Glim," Bow's voice sounded panicked over the phone line, "Are you out of your mind?!"

"What, Bow," she laughed. "I'm not going to cause any problems. I thought it would be good to, I don't know, *observe* them."

"Where are you in the house right now?"

"The kitchen. Thought I'd make us some snacks for girls' day."

"Do me a favor. Look at the fridge."

She thought it was strange, but she turned around and inspected the appliance. Held up by the ridiculous tourist magnets they had collected over the years were different photos of the group. "Oh, shit," she mumbled. "I see what you mean."

"Right! Our place is a veritable Catra and Adora memory landmine!"

"Okay, okay," Glimmer took a deep breath. "We need to stay calm. I've got time to put everything up. I'll stick it all in the closet in our bedroom."

"Everything, Glim, it has to be everything."

"I've got it. No one's breaking with reality on my watch," she laughed. She grabbed a big laundry basket and began filling it with all of the photos and other items she thought might trigger her friends.

"Did you figure out anything new, by the way?"

"No, but that Dr. Hordak is a total creep." She frowned as she took down the sketch Catra had made of the two of them as an engagement present. "His only suggestion was that I try to break them up. Can you believe that?"

"Ridiculous. There's no way we're doing that."

"Exactly. The first thing we need to figure out is how Catra ended up there. I just don't know *how* we figure that out." She paused to let him chime in, but he was silent for longer than she expected. "Bow? Are you there?"

"Yeah, I'm sorry," he sounded defeated again. "It's just... I didn't tell you, because it hurt too bad once we found out, but she called me that day. I missed it because of a meeting. She left me a voicemail about wanting my advice before doing something stupid. I let her down, Glim. I told her to call me if she needed anything and I wasn't there. I could've stopped this."

"You can't beat yourself up about that. It's not your fault. Okay?" Glimmer was shocked but trying not to make him feel worse than he already did. "Can you forward it to me? Maybe there's a clue in there."

"I'll send it in a minute. I love you. I've got to get back to work."

"I love you too," she replied and hung up. Her laundry basket of Catradora memories was getting hard to carry at this point, but she managed to get it up the stairs and into the closet, where she threw sweaters over it.

After inspecting everything two more times, she decided that she could officially settle back into snack-making duty.

The voicemail had come through, and she listened to it a few times while cooking, trying to parse together anything she could. It *definitely* didn't sound like a farewell, 'I won't remember you after this' voicemail. Catra referenced the wedding and talking to

him later. She didn't come off as emotional as Glimmer would've expected if she were giving up on Adora entirely. Not after how disgustingly in love the two had been since they first met. It sounded nearly as casual as one might call a friend to ask, "Do you think bangs are a good idea?" Something was very wrong with how this all came to be.

"Hey Adora," Catra said as soon as the phone line picked up. "I'm really sorry, but I have to stand you and Sparkles up."

"Damn," the other woman whined. "I was really looking forward to hearing your takes on Glimmer's taste in tv."

"Trust me, I'd much rather do that," she laughed as she locked her apartment door behind her. "But my advisor called, turns out he found out about some kind of weird brain study I might qualify for. If I get picked for it, they'll cover grad school and my living expenses."

"Whoa, that's amazing! They're not taking your brain out, are they?"

"I hope not," she headed down the stairs. "It has to do with connections and thought processes."

"And since you're such a big brain, you're very valuable."

"Well, I didn't want to be the one to say it. Tell Sparkles I'm really sorry, and that I'll take her up on the offer next Saturday if it's still good."

"Of course! I'm sure she'll understand. She and Bow both wanted to do grad school, but their undergrad loans were already insane. I hope everything goes well. I bet you have a really good-looking brain."

"Thanks," Catra chuckled. "Maybe we can still meet up again this weekend."

"I'll be waiting. Bye, love you." At least, she thought the other woman had said love you. She had gasped to herself, and her voice dropped away.

"Bye, Adora," she smiled as she hung up the phone.

On the ride to Prime Research Group, she pulled up their website on her phone and began reading to help prepare herself for what she was getting into. Nothing appeared to hint at surprise lobotomies; seemed safe enough. She could hardly focus on the words because her thoughts kept drifting to the possibility that Adora had said she loved her. Love? They had known each other for only a couple of days. Why did that feel like the right word to use for her too?

After trying to reread a paragraph for the third time, her phone began to ring and she saw one of her new contacts pop up. She raised an eyebrow and answered, "Hello?"

"Catra! It's Bow. You remember me, right?"

"Um, yeah," she laughed. "I almost washed my underwear at your house today. It's safe to say I know who you are."

Thank god , she thought she heard him whisper to himself before speaking to her again, "Glimmer filled me in on why you had to cancel. Sounds pretty cool!"

"Yeah, right? I can't even believe it. Hope my brain doesn't disappoint."

"Where is it that you're going exactly? I was wondering if I could apply too."

"I don't know if I want your brain's competition," she teased at first. "It's Prime Research Group. I'm in a taxi on my way over there now, it's off the highway in a strip mall."

"Catra. I know you don't know me very well," his voice had dropped into the most serious tone she'd heard from the very

pleasant man. "But you need to trust me. Do NOT go there. Please. Have the taxi drop you off anywhere else, I'll come to get you. Those people aren't what they say they are."

"Bow, don't get me wrong. I like you and all, but I like the idea of free grad school even better. How do you know this is a scam or some shit?"

"Because it happened to my best friend, and they hurt her. Please, call them and tell them you have to reschedule because you're sick or something, but do not go there. I'll explain more when I pick you up."

Geek Squad

Chapter Summary

> Bow comes to the rescue, but things don't go as smoothly as he hoped. Catra tries to understand what is happening in her dreams.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow hadn't thought twice about leaving work to rescue Catra from ending up back at Prime Enterprises. Now that he was on his way to pick her up from the gas station she'd been dropped off at instead, he had plenty of time to think. How exactly was he going to explain this? These people had been adamant that trying to help Catra or Adora remember was detrimental to their grasp of reality. On the other hand, they were clearly playing dirty by bribing Catra to lure her back into their office. Maybe he shouldn't believe everything they said.

He waved to Catra as he parked, and she hopped up from the bench where she had been waiting. Once she got in the car, she looked at him suspiciously. "They let me reschedule to Monday after work. Now, what the fuck is going on? While I was waiting, I searched every combination of Prime Research Group and scam synonym I could think of. I got nothing."

"They went by a different name when my friend went there."

"Well, out with it, then," she pulled her legs up into the seat and sat against the car door so that she was facing him. "What did they do to her? Was it awful enough to give up, oh, say 60k and some change?"

"I promise, it was. I don't know how it worked exactly, but they altered her memories. They made her forget some of the most important people and events of her life."

"That's some sci-fi shit, Bow. You seriously made me almost lose out on this for a crazy story like that?"

Bow sighed heavily and rubbed his temples as he tried to think. His only idea seemed rather ridiculous. "Okay, I understand why you don't believe me. I wouldn't either," he unbuckled and turned so that he could face her. He stuck his right hand out, "Shake my hand."

"I've really got to talk to Adora about her choice in friends." Catra smirked but stuck her hand out to meet his, "This is getting weirder and weirder."

Without another word, Bow tapped his thumb twice on the top of her hand. As he had hoped, this initiated a ridiculously complicated 'secret handshake' the two of them had come up with. Muscle memory was stored in a totally different way after all. Catra's eyes went wide as she watched her hand perform all of the motions on its own, and as they parted, they whispered simultaneously, "Geek Squad."

"Okay, now I'm really freaked out," Catra pulled her knees into her chest. "What was that, Bow?!"

"That's our secret handshake. We came up with it after we won a video game tournament at Brightmoon," Bow explained and carefully watched her reactions. "Glim and Adora tease us about it every time we do it."

"Geek Squad is our duo name," Catra whispered, still in disbelief.

"Exactly, see, you remember," Bow gave a reassuring smile, "Because the four of us make the Best Friend Squad."

Catra started breathing rapidly and curled into herself further. "This isn't real. That didn't happen. I... I just met you... I just met Adora and.. Sparkles. Nothing makes any sense. What's happening to me? Why are you doing this to me?" She was shaking now, and her whole face had turned red.

"Catra, I know this is a lot to try to process, but I think you're having a panic attack. Let's focus on helping with that," Bow did his level best to remain calm. "Do you have your rescue medicine in your bag?"

"I think so," she turned so she could sit properly and dig into her backpack. She produced the bottle in question and took a pill with some water he handed her.

"Good, okay, focus on breathing for a bit. We don't have to talk about this anymore until you're ready."

Catra sat with her head hung low as tears flowed down her cheeks. Still, he could tell she had listened to him as he watched her shaky breaths start to become more regular and deep. Finally, she looked over to him, "Nothing makes any sense. I'm... scared. I just.. I wanna see Adora, please. Take me to Adora."

"Yes, of course," he agreed, worried she might leap out of the car if he refused. "We'll go crash girls' afternoon. Glim was working on snacks when we last talked."

"Okay," Catra softly replied, she buckled herself up and leaned her head against the car window.

Before starting the car, Bow sent off a quick text to his fiance, "I may have made a huge mistake. On our way over."

Catra opened her eyes and looked around the office. The sedative she had been given must not have been strong enough because it seemed she was only out for a few seconds. As she sat up from the hospital bed they had laid her down in, she looked to Dr. Entrapta furiously typing and clicking at her computer. "Hey, dunno why, but that didn't work. Normally I can sleep anywhere, anytime; no meds needed."

The scientist didn't address her. She said.. something, but it wasn't to her, and it was so muffled it didn't make any sense. So

Catra turned and looked to the other doctor. He clearly said something to the other woman, but she got nothing again. "Think I have some side effects. Little help? Hello?" She got up from the table, the cords falling away as though they weren't connected. When she came around the computer to look at... the name escaped her suddenly. Well, as she looked at whoever this was, Catra jumped as she was met with a blank face staring back at her. "The fuck is going on?"

She didn't have much time to think about it before she felt the sensation of falling, and she was staring up at the ceiling of somewhere new. Wait, she knew this ceiling.

"It's a big deal when you're getting drunk with her, and I'm sitting here worrying about you. We both KNOW she has a crush on you. It's fucked up, Catra. I thought you had more respect for our relationship than this." Maybe she had passed out, and that weird office was a dream? This fight, however, was very real. She felt sober enough from her micro-nap to handle it now, though.

"Whoa, calm down," Catra sat up from the bed, "I would never do anything to hurt you, Adora. I love you. Scorpia's dating the new girl at the cafe, or I wouldn't have invited her. I thought I told you already. Listen, I was stupid turning off my phone without saying something, I know. I didn't mean to worry you."

"Oh." All the anger had drained from her voice. "I love you too. I'm really sorry I overreacted. I get jealous sometimes."

"Yeah, and normally it's a fucking turn on, but the being yelled at part, not so much," Catra joked, "Why don't we kiss and make-up?"

"I'd really like that," the blonde smiled and made her way back over to the bed. "I missed you."

"I'm right here, princess," Catra winked as she reached up for her to pull her down on the bed.

Only, then, she wasn't. She was in the courtyard in front of the university building that housed most of her classes. "What the fuck is happening," she asked mostly to herself, but then she was answered.

"Um, hopefully, lunch! If you stop standing there like a *dummy,"* Adora grabbed for her hand. "Gotta hurry if we want to get back you back to class on time. Come on, it's too chilly to stand around anyway."

"Sorry, I'm feeling really weird right now," she hurried along with Adora, squeezing her hand to ground herself, "I feel like.. I don't know.. I'm losing time or something."

"Have you been abducted by aliens," Adora asked with a laugh. "Is this because of that weird movie you and Bow made us watch?"

"No, I don't think so," she continued trying to put things together. "Do you... do you remember that awful fight we had? About... um, the concert? And Scorpia?"

"What are you talking about? We've never had a big fight, and the concert's not for two more weeks. Is she being weird at the cafe again? I swear I'll come in there and teach her a thing or two about personal space," she narrowed her eyes and looked very serious.

"No, she's been fine. Fuck, what's going on with me," Catra sighed and shook her head. "Nothing makes sense."

Adora stopped and wrapped her in her arms, brushing some of her long curly hair away to kiss her neck softly. "I know this is pretty ridiculous coming from me, but maybe you need to take a break. You've been working so hard. Why don't you see if you can get some of your shifts covered? Then you could focus on school. I could help out with bills if you come up short."

"Thanks, Adora," Catra held onto her and breathed in the sweet smell of her perfume. "That probably---" She felt another pulse of

kind of weird energy, and she held on to her girlfriend with all her might. "It's happening again."

By the time they made it back to the other couple's home, Catra's medicine had kicked in fully, and she was having a hard time keeping herself awake. It had been a long time since she needed to take it, and she forgot how much it made her feel loopy. All the same, this was a better feeling than whatever was happening to her as Bow tried to explain his nonsensical story. She tried to focus on the details of what he told her, but it felt like as soon as she reached for something in her mind, it floated away. No matter. She would see Adora soon, and she knew deep down that would help.

Bow helped her out of the car and into the house quietly. He hadn't ventured any more conversation on the drive home, and Catra was grateful for that. He was a nice guy, but he clearly had too big of an imagination. When they entered, the person she really needed to see hopped up from the couch and rushed over to them.

"Catra! I didn't think you were coming," Adora wrapped her arms around her in a quick hug.

"I didn't either," she answered groggily, "Thing's rescheduled."

"Are you okay," Adora nervously asked and then looked to Bow.

He quickly provided an answer, "She had a panic attack, but she'll be okay. Already took medicine for it."

"Mmhmm," Catra hummed into Adora's shoulder, "Now I'm real sleepy, sleepy. Come nap with me, 'Dora."

Glimmer looked past the other couple to her fiance, who shrugged at her helpelessly. "That's a great idea. I'll finish your laundry, and we'll all have dinner together when you get up."

"I could always go for a nap," Adora laughed and moved from the hug to holding onto her hand. "Come on, sleepy."

Catra whined, "Carry me, please, you always carry me to bed after I gotta take it."

"Oh," Adora raised an eyebrow. "Sure, why not." With that, she gently maneuvered the other woman into her arms and carried her upstairs.

Once she safely deposited her in the guest bed, she climbed in beside her. "Do you want to talk about it," Adora whispered.

"What," Catra said with a yawn.

Adora looked sheepily back at her. "You know, whatever made you feel bad. We don't have to if you don't want."

"Can't talk about it," she shook her head back and forth slowly. "Brain's too fuzzy."

"Okay, love. Let's get some sleep."

"Heh," Catra laughed to herself as she rolled over, "You called me love."

"Pfft," Adora tried to play it off. "No, I didn't. Your fuzzy brain heard me wrong."

"Hear with my ears, dummy," Catra giggled. "My ears aren't fuzzy."

"Aren't they," Adora tickled the one she could reach, "Maybe you've grown fuzzy, cute ears like Melog."

"Bah," Catra complained as she rolled back over to face her. "I wanna be big spoon. Roll over."

"Of course," Adora complied and was immediately claimed by all of Catra's limbs.

"Love you, 'Dora," was the last thing Catra got out before she faded off to sleep.

"Don't stop!" Adora whined as she threw her head back against the door.

Catra had no intention of even pausing. God, they were cramped here in the backseat though. Her own legs were beginning to spasm, and, decidedly, not from pleasure.

"I'm trying," Catra huffed. She bit down on the nipple of the breast that was bouncing in front of her face. When she released, she laughed as she started to scold her, "You're the one that wanted to save money splitting a hotel room with Sparkles and Bow. Told you that you couldn't resist me for a night."

"This, uh, isn't, fuck," Adora started, but her ability to make words seemed to fall away, her voice breaking into desperate noises.

"What's that, love," Catra teased, brushing her thumb against her just right. "You're not making sense."

As soon as the words fell out of her mouth, Catra felt like she had been shocked. She unceremoniously ceased all attempts at pleasure as she sat up in the backseat of the SUV. "Wait, wait, hold on. I don't... this already happened, Adora."

Adora whimpered at the loss of her touch and complained, "Nothing's happened; please don't tease me when I'm this close," she grabbed for her hand and tried to pull her back down.

"I think... this is a dream," Catra thought aloud, continuing to look around the space, "I think I'm dreaming in the doctor's office. They're doing stuff to my brain."

"It's going to be a nightmare if you don't finish this."

"Hmm," Catra paused and thought. "If this is a dream, then I control it." With that, she focused on what she wanted to happen. In response, Adora rolled her hips up at her as she cried out her name. "Okay, better now, horny dreamdora?"

"Uh-huh," she sighed contently. "Even if I don't understand what's happening."

"We're fighting in the real world right now. Wasn't either of our best moments, to tell the truth. I took it hard, it threw some stuff off balance for me, and I went to a doctor that could help so I didn't have to repeat a class."

"Well, what's a doctor going to do to make us stop fighting," Adora pulled her sweatpants back on and sat up.

"Fixing," she tried to remember. It was really fuzzy now. She could hardly remember what the doctor's office looked like. "Fixing, something. Fixing my brain. They're out there right now. It's like whatever they're doing is making me relive my memories."

"If this is a memory, it's a good one," Adora winked. "What's there to fix about this?"

"Nothing," Catra replied. "This was a perfect trip, even with the leg cramps."

"That doesn't sound right then," she shrugged. "Weird."

Before they could discuss it further, they both cried out in confusion and clung to each other as the SUV dropped to the ground. It seemed as though the tires had all popped at once. Catra grabbed for Adora's hand, and they leaped out of the vehicle. No, the tires hadn't popped. They were... gone, and slowly but surely, the rest of the SUV was going with them. Blinking right out of existence.

Bewildered Adora stood in shock, "I don't think rental insurance covers this!"

"Come on," Catra pulled her hand and started running towards the hotel. Only, it was starting to blur out too.

"Catra," Adora called, and she looked back at her. "What's happening to me?"

As she spoke, Adora's form started to mold and blank out the same way that the doctor's had in the office. Even if she knew it wasn't real, Catra screamed all the same and tried to grab for her again. By the time she should've connected, her mental world shifted again.

"Row, row, row your boat," she heard her girlfriend terribly singing beside her along with the rhythmic sound of the rowing machine she was on. "Pfft, Catra! Are you giving up already?"

Catra realized when and where she was now. She dropped the handle she was holding and stood up from the machine. "I think I know what they're doing," she said with a terrified look on her face.

"Um, who? What? This is a lame way to back out of a challenge," Adora slowly stopped her own motion and took a big drink from her water bottle. "I was really excited to beat you!"

"Adora, think. Okay. You're.. my memory, so you know what I know. So... think, what were we just talking about it in the car?"

Adora stood from the machine and puzzled over it. "Doctors are fixing your brain, right?"

"Yes! Only, I don't know. I think their version of fixing things means deleting them."

"Is that what they're supposed to do?"

"No!" She stomped her foot for emphasis. "They were supposed to help me with my emotions and shit. Make me less.. um..."

"Human? Everyone has emotions, Catra," Adora smiled reassuringly. "Let's split a smoothie and talk about this."

"If we're here, they're going to erase it, and I'll lose you again... and again... and then, what if it's the last you? Then you'll be gone."

"I definitely don't want to be gone. Do you want me gone?"

"No, of course not. Come on," Catra held out her hand. "I've got an idea. They mapped out memories specific to you. Maybe if I take you somewhere weird, they won't find you."

Glimmer and Bow sat at their small dining room table staring at the loading screen of Catra's laptop. He had grabbed it from her backpack when she left to go sleep with Adora.

Glimmer nervously watched and waited, "You sure you know her password still? If we get locked out, she'll notice."

"They wouldn't have had to reset it. It's melog and some numbers, not Adora related," he answered. "At least.. I hope so. I want to check her email. The whole thing with her university advisor got me thinking. *Why* would he recommend her to them for this bogus scholarship? He's got to be in on it, or if he's not, they're tricking him too." He tried the password and held back a cheer when it worked.

"Don't get too excited," Glimmer frowned. "I bet they deleted all their digital fingerprints."

"Maybe, maybe," Bow nodded, and then he opened up the email application. Sure enough, there was nothing in the inbox regarding the study. Even her trashcan was empty. Still, he had a hunch. "AH-HA!" Glimmer shushed him and gestured at the ceiling where the sleeping women were. He turned the laptop to show her, "They always forget the sent folder!"

"Babe, you're brilliant."

"Thank you." He really needed that win. He opened the most recent reply Catra had sent, "Oh. Fuck."

Glimmer gasped as she realized the same thing, "Her graduation advisor is the creepy brainwashing doctor's brother."

"THIS. IS. CRAZY," Bow whisper-yelled to Glimmer. "What does this even mean?!"

"I don't know, but it CAN'T be legal. Manipulating students to drum up business for your brother? No way." she shook her head. "Send these to the printer. We can't afford to lose them."

"On it," Bow popped open every email related to this and the last referral. He continued reading while the prints started, "Glim, they tricked her. They definitely tricked her."

"How many other people have they done this to," Glimmer wondered aloud. "All those... *success* stories, Bow. What if the same thing happened to them?"

"If we can prove it happened to Catra, maybe we can save them too. I know she's in there, Glim. I tried the handshake, and she knew it. It freaked her out, though."

"Oh my god, seriously," she whisper-yelled as she shook her head, "That was your huge mistake? You gave the poor girl a panic attack to relive Geek Squad?! Bow, I love you, but you're an idiot."

Chapter End Notes

> Not me extending the chapter count again because I like breaking the story up into manageable chunks for writing/reading.
>
> Let me know what you think! It's *fascinating* to me to write and explore this world.

Also, Bow & Catra Friendship Lore: I imagine that they decided they needed a cool handshake for their gaming team after binge-watching Community together and admiring Troy & Abed's. But also their's is like, complicated AF. So complicated I couldn't bring it to words if I tried.

Meet me in Eternia

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora struggle with maintaining their memoryscapes. Glimmer and Bow, on the verge of cracking the case, get an offer of help from an unexpected source.

Chapter Notes

> How happy is the blameless vestal's lot! The world forgetting, by the world, forgot. Eternal sunshine of the spotless mind! Each pray'r accepted, and each wish resign'd.
>
> - Alexander Pope

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wondered if she should feel guilty about enjoying this extra buff, tall version of her girlfriend---especially considering the circumstance that led to it. Still, it certainly was more pleasant than the utter despair she felt before. Six-foot Catra had lifted and pressed her hard against the cool lockers behind them. The brunette's lips were hungrily making their way up from her chest to her neck. Adora dug her nails into her muscular back.

"Now, what else can we do in this dream world, hmm," Catra whispered against her skin.

"I don't, ah, know exactly," she exhaled sharply as the other woman moved her hands down lower and squeezed. "What do you---"

"Whoa, what the fuck," Catra interrupted her. She took a step back and put the blonde back down.

Adora stared in confusion as Catra's form began to shift and pulse between the shape of Elyse, who belonged here, and snow day Catra, who did not. Once they were completely separated, Catra's

eyes filled with fear, and she reached out for her with a last, "Adora!"

Adora rushed forward, trying to make contact and take her to another memory, but she was too late. Catra was gone. Again. She failed. She collapsed down to the ground and held her head in her hands.

"Are you ready? Blindfold's coming off now," she heard Catra's voice call to her. All at once, she realized she wasn't in the locker room memory anymore. She listened to a car door close behind her and felt the soft fabric around her eyes begin to fall away. "Happy Birthday!"

She opened her eyes, and Catra swung around to her front again. The other woman was dressed adorably dorky and outside of her usual style. Her curly hair was braided into pigtails and topped with a cowboy hat to go along with a plaid button-up shirt and jeans. "I hope you realize how much I love you to wear this stupid thing," she joked as she tipped the cowboy hat at her then smirked, "Don't worry, I brought you one too," she grabbed it off the top of the rental car and put it on Adora's head.

This was a month ago. Catra had surprised her with a trip to the most ridiculous place either of them had ever been: a horse "museum." She had made a big deal of blindfolding and stealing her away on an hour long drive for it. Only, it turned out that "museum" actually meant three trailers connected together that were decorated with various horse trinkets and toys the owner had collected over her life. It was wonderfully strange.

Catra frowned and went to hold her hands, "What's wrong? I'm sorry if this is too stupid... we can just go out to eat. I thought you'd--"

"Catra, I love it," Adora smiled and wrapped her into a hug, squeezing her tight, "I love you. This was my best birthday ever."

"I love you too, dummy," she held her back just as tight, "But, hey, don't go saying it's the best ever until we start. Some parts of this brochure are giving me serious creep vibes," she released the hug and pulled the 'Horse Dreams' pamphlet from her shirt pocket. "There apparently is a whole display dedicated to horse toys recovered from landfills."

"That wasn't even the weirdest part," Adora laughed, recalling the memory, "The owner telling us we'd need tissues for how much we'd be *drooling* over everything, that's what I'll never forget."

"Wait? Have you been here before without me?! I asked Sparkles and Bow; they both said they'd never heard of it," she groaned before raising an eyebrow, "Also, what the fuck? Who says that?"

"Catra, do you remember?" Adora softly said as she brought her back into another desperate embrace, "I know you're not really you."

They stood there in silence, holding onto one another as the world around them began to blip and blur away. Finally, Catra quietly said, "Oh."

"I'm so sorry," Adora kissed the side of her cheek as tears began rolling down her own again. There wouldn't be any tears left to cry in the real world, but here the supply was endless---a whole ocean's worth of lament.

"I need to think this through again." Catra released her abruptly and took off the hat as though it was restricting her brain, "That memory, it wasn't far enough off track. Plus, I made the mistake of wanting to get my giant fucking hands on you. Maybe that looks the same as our memories to them? Take me deeper. Some time and place way before you knew me."

"It won't work," Adora cried; she was so overwhelmed at this point. She didn't feel like she had any right left to hope.

"No, not again," Catra reached for her hand and squeezed. "It's either this or give up. Do you want to give up on us? On me?"

"Never," Adora shook her head, blinking away the tears. "Stay with me," she brought Catra into her arms tight again and focused on a new place to be.

"Oh my god, Catra," Adora started laughing so hard she had to pause and catch her breath, "Chess Players Have Great Moves? And you have the nerve to call me a dork?"

"Hey, fuck off. This club got me one of my biggest scholarships," Catra narrowed her eyes at what she had taken to calling Dreamdora, the spliced memory version of her girlfriend. She looked down at her high school chess club t-shirt, "I'll admit the shirt is stupid, but I was out the day they voted on it. And I won a huge tournament in this dumb thing."

"Impressive, Geek Squad! You have always been the most adorable nerd," she smirked as she made her way across the empty classroom.

"Check yourself out," she pointed over to the lab sink and mirror in the classroom. She laughed to herself as Adora took in the same sight she had. Her appearance had been mixed with one of Catra's teammates through some process of her mind trying to make sense of Adora's existence here. She was wearing a dorky sweater vest over a button-up with a matching skirt and oxfords.

"Heh," Adora smiled at her reflection. "I think I'm pretty cute in this, actually."

"Agreed, but we've got other things to worry about right now," Catra made her way up to the whiteboard and started to map out her thoughts and theories.

"Can I help?" Adora offered as she came up behind her and rested her chin on her shoulder.

"This isn't usually your kind of thing," she tapped back of the marker against her chin while she thought. "What we know is they

said this was to help with my emotions. Get me back on track and all. I thought it was weird, but I didn't ask enough questions," she sighed, and Adora started rubbing her shoulders. "Thanks. They had me bring items related to you since our fight is what got me upset. But... they had me bring *everything* from home that was from or related to you."

"That seems like overkill."

"It does. Now that I think about it, it all seems like too much. Them altering things in regards to our fight, that's something like what I agreed to. But them messing up the couple's trip and mapping all of my thoughts about you? I think they might be erasing you specifically. All of you."

Adora gasped at the thought, "Wake up! Tell them to stop!"

"I don't think it's that easy," Catra groaned.

"Sure it is," Adora spun her around and held onto her shoulders. "If anyone can do this, it's you. Come on, Catra."

"Sure, I'll just will myself to wake up even after that damn sedative they gave me," Catra rolled her eyes.

"I'll.. um.. I'll pinch you!" Adora offered and reached out, grabbing onto Catra's upper arm and pinching hard.

"Fuck, Adora, that hurt, and it won't--"

"Dr. Hordak!" Entrapta called over to her boss.

Catra tried hard to focus, to get her body to listen to her, but all she could do was flutter her eyelids open and look over at the pig-tailed doctor.

"What now," Dr. Hordak grumpily asked as he got up from where he was reviewing information on his own computer. "Have you

finally solved *your* unfortunate errors in her brain map?"

"She's awake. Possibly because we are doing this in the office instead of at home with her regular circadian rhythm. I did think this was an unusual deviation from our regular procedure." She gestured towards the woman who was now staring at her. "Hello. Can you hear me, Catra? Don't be scared."

"I've explicitly asked you to not speak to this patient," he admonished her and started rummaging through the cabinets. "Especially not in this vulnerable state."

"Perhaps we should allow her to wake fully? The data I'm seeing may indicate resistance to the procedure, and I want to--"

"No, absolutely not," Dr. Hordak growled as he came back over, preparing an injection. "I am going to give her a stronger sedative. I need more time to fix your mistakes. If you are not going to follow my instructions exactly, you will be dismissed."

"Yes, Dr. Hordak," Entrapta defeatedly replied.

Catra's eyes went wide, and she tried so hard to make her voice work, make anything move. Then the needle pierced her skin, and she was gone.

Adora was woken from her nap by her sleeping partner suddenly shaking and grabbing onto her tighter as she whimpered her name.

"Catra," she wiggled around in her arms to face her. She ran a hand gently through her soft, short hair. "You're safe. I'm here."

"Good," she replied in her sweet, sleepy voice and kissed her tenderly. "Worried you were gone."

"I'm not going anywhere," Adora assured her and pulled Catra in close to rest her head against her chest, "Did you have a bad

dream?"

"Mmhmm. Took you away. Couldn't save you. Hurt," she mumbled as she snuggled into her breasts, "So soft."

"Thanks," Adora couldn't help but giggle a little before reassuring her, "No one is going to take me away, I promise. You can go back to sleep," she kissed the top of her head.

"Okay, 'Dora. Love you."

"Love you too," Adora whispered, chancing that she wouldn't remember when she finally was back to herself again.

Meanwhile, downstairs, Bow and Glimmer were busy trying to complete as much research as possible while the women were safe with them. Armed with now two of the other aliases of the organization, Bow was trying to track down just how many different versions of 'Prime' there were. They knew Prime Enterprises, Prime Healing, and Prime Research Group. Now they had added Prime Harmony, Prime Power.

"I found another one!" Bow turned his laptop and showed another shell website that contained a variation on the same information as the others.

Glimmer looked over and scoffed, "Prime Enlightenment, these people really think they're doing something, don't they?"

"Yeah, this one promises to 'open' your mind to access your full potential," Bow shook his head and started making more notes. "They're all registered under the same information. So stupid. You'd think they would try to hide a little better."

"Well, maybe they don't have to worry about that because all their victims forget them!" Glimmer pointed out. "These research papers seem so bogus to me now. How do you even verify the success of a procedure if you can't even talk to the subject? Sure, Subject 44 may have achieved the focus needed to finish her dissertation after removing a personal distraction, but maybe S44

would've done that anyway?! Maybe S44 could've had the dissertation *and* the personal distraction, whatever that means."

"Wait," Bow paused and looked over at her. "How many of the success stories refer to students? Maybe... I don't know; maybe this other Dr. Hordak is funneling people into the program."

"Oh, my, god," Glimmer's eyes went wide. "Bow, it's been so many! More than half for sure in the recent papers, and a lot were people on the edge of whatever it was they were trying to achieve. Obviously, it doesn't say what university they're attending, and they're all anonymous, but..."

Bow's eyes went wide as the puzzle pieces clicked together in his mind, "But what if university Dr. Hordak specifically preys on students at Brightmoon who were *going* to succeed anyway and uses them to help prove his brother's system works."

"That has to be it! The mother fuckers," Glimmer pounded her fist on the table and then whispered, "Oops, sorry. We have a conspiracy theory. What now?"

"I don't know," Bow frowned. "I mean, we can't bring this to the authorities, right? I'm sure they all signed paperwork that would excuse this."

"We could try working with Catra some more. See if she can remember anything? If you're right about her recalling your dumb Geek Squad stuff, surely she's got some more in that big brain of hers."

Before Bow had a chance to discuss this idea, Glimmer's phone began ringing. The caller-id read: Prime Enterprises.

"Why are they calling?! They know we're on to them," Bow panicked.

"Only one way to find out. Get your phone out; we're recording this," Glimmer answered before swapping to speakerphone. "Hello."

"Hello, this is Dr. Entrapta at Prime Enterprises. I was trying to reach Glimmer. Is this you?"

"Yes," she looked over at Bow, who shrugged at her. "Are you calling about my friends, Catra and Adora?"

"I am, in fact. I've been reviewing the data and reflecting on my notes from their procedures like I said I would when we spoke. I have some fascinating theories as to why they found each other."

"Okay. Are you actually going to tell me something this time?"

"I am not certain, but I believe that both subjects were intentionally resisting the procedure."

"I see," Glimmer tried to sound unaffected while she mouthed 'Mother Fuckers' again at Bow.

"I would like an opportunity to interview and examine them."

"And why should we allow you to do that? If they were resisting the procedure, we don't want you to finish it!"

"I think I may be able to help. Recovery could be possible. It's impossible to know for sure unless I examine them."

Glimmer looked to Bow again, and he nodded. "Okay. Ground rules. No Dr. Hordaks. Not one."

"Understood." She sounded slightly confused.

"You may bring yourself and your equipment to our home. We aren't going to let you take them anywhere."

"Perfect. I wouldn't be able to see them here anyway! I suspect I'd get in trouble for this."

"What do you mean by that?"

"May we talk about this when I arrive? I need to get everything packed up."

"Okay. Fine. You have our address on record?"

"We do. I will be there within the next two hours. Farewell!"

With that, the line went dead.

When Adora opened her eyes this time, she was in a place she had not been in a very, very long time: the space under the playground at her elementary school. She was crouched in the corner, and, even if she knew it was a memory, she felt the sting of anxiety in her heart about what was to come.

"Whoa, Dummy," a younger, silly version of Catra's voice said beside her, "We're way back now! Ah, man. I kept that dumb outfit."

She looked over at her to see an approximation of 7-year-old Catra still wearing her cowboy get-up from the birthday. Adora wore one of her usual school outfits -- shorts and a silly t-shirt (this one had a pegasus on it that said: Believe in Your Dreams).

"Sssh," she instructed the other girl. "Gotta be quiet!"

"What? We have to be silent until you wake up; that's boring."

"Catra shush," Adora put her tiny hands over her mouth and whispered, "They're out there! Looking for me!"

"Who," Catra mumbled through her hands.

The small opening to their hiding spot was now filled with the angry face of a boy their age. "FOUND HER! COME OUT AND PLAY, ADORKA. "

"Fuck off," Catra kicked at him with her little boots, hitting him in the nose and sending him reeling backward.

"Now you've done it!" Another, slightly older voice called. Eventually, the two of them were dragged out, kicking and screaming.

Catra stood in front of Adora and scowled at the gathering of children. "Back the fuck up, all of you!" She curled her hands into fists. "I'll fuck you up so bad your parents will have to take out loans for your plastic surgery."

"Catra, no," Adora whined behind her. "We can't fight them all."

"Smart Adorka! If you was this smart yesterday, wouldn't be no problems," the boy who Catra had kicked warned them.

"I can't tell if you're too young to know proper grammar or if you're as dumb as you're ugly," Catra was not wavering. "Now, who's going to be the first to lose an adult tooth?"

"I dunno, Scott," another kid said to the leader. "This one's scary! I've never seen her before."

"Yeah, I'm a god damn guardian angel. Stay the fuck away from Adora," Catra moved forward and grabbed the other boy by the collar of his shirt. Despite being a few inches shorter than him, she looked like the one with all the power here. "Got it, Scottie? Or do you need me to kick you hard enough to make your balls drop early?"

"You're not worth getting detention anyway!" He pretended to be cool about it.

"That's what I thought," Catra released his shirt. "Run along now."

With that, all the kids ran away, leaving Adora and Catra alone. The latter turned around and grinned smugly, "What'd you do to make those kids mad anyway?"

"I stopped them from stealing from Miss Mary's prize jar," Adora whined.

"Aw, that's great; I'm proud of you," Catra gave her a hug before grabbing her hand and leading her into the playground. "Ooh, swings. Let's swing until morning. Do you remember what we're doing?"

"Um, hmm," Adora puzzled while she was being led. It suddenly came to her. "Oh! Ha. Sorry, I guess I got stuck in kid brain."

"You're a charming kid," Catra mused. "What really happened here? Did they get to beat you up?"

"Yeah, until Miss Mary came back from the bathroom," Adora frowned. "I did give Scott a black eye, though."

They stayed together on the swings for a long time, chatting, enjoying this tucked-away corner of Adora's memory world. It seemed as though this was really going to work. Unfortunately, the peaceful time on the swings was interrupted as Adora felt herself being pulled back to the correct timeline. Everything sped up now. She couldn't talk to a Catra long enough to try again, as much as she wanted to. There wasn't even time left to cry--- only time to watch as the most precious memories of her life flashed by her, fading into oblivion. Mercifully, everything finally slowed down.

"It worked," Catra exclaimed once she was back in the classroom with Adora. "For a second, anyway. The female doctor, Entrapta, she was there. She knew I woke up, but I couldn't say anything."

"Maybe she'll stop it? If she knows this isn't right."

"She wanted to. He wouldn't let her. That's why she barely talked to me during the whole mapping. I thought that was weird!" She revised her whiteboard notes to include the new things she had learned. "This is what he was always going to do. It’s what he wanted; he didn't care if I didn't want it."

Adora clenched up a fist as she growled, "I am going to punch that mother fucker."

"Yeah, if I know the real world you, you might," Catra chuckled a little to herself. "God... unless, Adora, what if you think I did it on purpose? Oh no, oh fuck." She started to write as fast as she could on the board -- analyzing the possible chain of reactions and what she knew about her girlfriend.

"What are you doing," Adora was standing behind her, trying to follow.

"I'm trying to game this out. If this works and I really don't remember you, and they tell you that I did it on purpose because... I think you'll do it too. Then... then what?"

"Hey, silly. Don't worry about that," Adora comforted her, kissing her on the cheek. "This is working."

Catra sighed, standing back to look at her work, "For now."

They stayed there in the classroom for what felt like an eternity. Catra was becoming fatigued, having to exert all of her energy to keep the memory stable. Adora, for her part, was holding her and helping to keep her calm.

"It hurts," Catra whimpered finally. It felt like a constant stream of electricity shocking her mind at this point.

Adora kissed her forehead. "It's okay to let go if you have to."

"No, Adora, I won't. I can't lose you," she started to cry, feeling defeated for the first time in this whole ridiculous process. "I need to hold on a little longer. They can't keep me asleep forever."

"Catra," Adora softly said, "I don't want this to hurt you."

"Losing you will hurt me," she argued.

She felt her consciousness starting to fade to black, and she desperately clawed at Adora to keep her with her. "Please, no, please." Suddenly, it seemed as though she was going through a faster, sloppier version of what was being done before. She would be in an Adora memory for a moment, and before she could do anything, it would be gone. She felt it all zooming past-- date nights at the movies, making dinner, Valentine's, birthdays, big events and small. Then... she was on the beach.

Adora was staring at the pegasus kite she desperately tried to fly as she ran along the beach. She'd been at this for longer than she wanted to admit. The wind caught it finally, and she was laughing like a little kid at the sight. She didn't take her eyes off the kite as she kept running, so excited that it was finally working.

When she had picked up the kite at the grocery store, a pure impulse purchase, Glimmer and Bow teased her about it. She argued that celebrating finishing their freshman year of college justified such childish behavior. They were further down on the beach, trying to get the grill going for lunch.

"Dummy, no!" she heard another woman call out to her.

Her attention was caught just quick enough to realize she was about to run right into a kid's sandcastle. She came to a stop in time not to lay waste to the creation. The child nearby, who must be its architect, gave her an angry look.

"Sorry, buddy," she gave an awkward smile. "Great work!"

At that time, the kite came falling back to the earth and struck right in the middle of the castle. While the child was not amused, she heard a swell of uproarious laughter. She picked up her kite from the slightly damaged structure. As she raised her head, Adora met eyes with the source of the laughter: a woman sitting on a set of stairs that led down to the sand from the street. Adora was sure she had never seen a more beautiful woman in her life--

- all golden brown skin, beautiful long curly hair tied up with a bandana, and a matching bikini paired with swim shorts. Even better, she was looking back at her with a flirty smile and waved. Adora apologized again and hurried her way up to the beach to meet this mysterious woman. A part of her wished that she *wasn't* carrying a pegasus kite, but what was she going to do? She had been caught already.

"Sorry," the other woman laughed again, "I should've warned you sooner."

"Oh, you're the one who called me Dummy?" Adora looked hurt before switching to a playful smile.

"Proudly. Even beach goddesses gotta look where they're going." She looked back down at the book she had been sketching in. "Might need to edit this now, though. I think I'll make it a comic where at the end, you attack a castle."

"Wait, you're drawing me," Adora questioned with big eyes, "Can I see?"

"Sure," she patted the stairs beside her. Adora happily accepted the offer to sit beside the woman. The drawing was of her running along the beach and looking like she was guiding a real, flying pegasus. "What do you think?"

"I love it," she said sincerely. Though the art she was most admiring was the way the freckles dotted the other woman's cheeks and her heterochromatic blue and honey-colored eyes.

"Thanks. You gave me a lot to work with out there. I've never seen someone take so long to get a kite flying <u>at the beach</u>. It's normally idiot proof!"

"Well, I am a dummy. I heard that once from a beautiful artist," Adora gave a smug smile, "People also call me Adora."

"Nice to meet you," she held out a hand, "Catra." As they shook, Catra pulled her closer and whispered, "*Meet me in Eternia.*"

Chapter End Notes

1 more chapter to go! Thoughts and feedback always welcomed. Thanks for sticking through this one! I meant to finish it up much faster than I have. I'm really proud of where it's gone though.

Okay

Chapter Summary

> And then my soul saw you and it kind of went, 'Oh, there you are. I've been looking for you' - Unknown

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra took in a deep, slow breath of salty air as the warm sun shown on her face. Finally. A moment to breathe. Time itself had been flowing backward with the intensity of a flood, but now all was tranquil. Everything was as it should be. She looked down at the beach below her and caught sight of Adora. The blonde was already coming her way, trudging up the hill with her pegasus kite in tow. Catra must have not been aware during the beginning of this treasured memory. She stood above her now, looking down at her with a cute, flirty smile. This was supposed to be her equally flirty line, but...

"Adora," she said quietly before she started breaking into pained sobs.

The blonde continued smiling and sat down beside her as she was supposed to. "Hey, Catra. You're okay, love. I'm here."

Catra threw herself at Adora with a hug so tight she worried she might break her. "I can't stop it. I'm so sorry. This is all my fault. If I didn't fuck up that night, if I just talked to you when you came by, if... God, why didn't I ask more questions? I'm so stupid."

"Sssh. We both know I'm a dummy; you're brilliant," the blonde assured her, pulling her over into her lap so they could be closer. "I love you. It's not your fault. You didn't want this."

"I love you so much." Catra kissed her once on the lips and then desperately all over her face. She wanted to show how much she

loved every inch of her. She pulled back and looked into her blue eyes adoringly, "Meeting you here was the best thing that ever happened to me, and now... it's going to be gone like it meant nothing."

"We're soul mates, remember? We decided that right here when we exchanged numbers, and we both had the same phone case. That's like *magic."* Adora rubbed Catra's back reassuringly. "Our souls will find each other again. I hope I'm doing something less embarrassing when you see me next."

Catra laughed a little through her tears. "Are you kidding? I hope you're doing something even dumber. It's so damn cute." She pulled her attention away from Adora long enough to realize that *it* had started. "It's happening. Should we... we could run, maybe, get a few more minutes."

"Mmm, we could," she moved a hand up to turn Catra's gaze back to her. "Or we could enjoy what we have now and relax."

Catra didn't want to admit it, but she was right. There wasn't any point in making this more painful. "I love you," she said as she stared at her, begging her mind to hold on to something. Anything.

"I love you too," Adora brought her into a kiss as the world began to fade away around them. In the last moment, she broke away and whispered in her ear, "Eternia."

As soon as Catra opened her eyes, she sincerely regretted it. What little sunshine was pouring in through her bedroom was launching a full-on assault. It was *almost* as bad as her alarm that she finally got her bearings straight to silence. "Fucking a," she mumbled to herself as she tried to remember what led to her being in this state. She must have gone out drinking the night before, but damned if she remembered a single thing about it. Hell, she was still fully dressed in her regular clothes. Apparently,

she wanted to make up for four years of being a reasonably responsible student in one night.

She grabbed for her phone to see if she could uncover any idea of what she had gotten into. "Of course," she sighed as she saw the error about losing data due to an update. She tinkered with it for a few minutes but couldn't make heads or tails of that either. Giving up for now, she cautiously rose from her bed to go check on Melog. She found him sitting on the floor staring at the front door.

"Hey, buddy." He looked back at her and meowed. "Yeah, I know. I'm a bad mom. I'm sorry." She lifted him up in her arms and kissed his soft head. "Please forgive me. Who else is going to love me, huh?" He licked her chin, and she took that for apology accepted.

After placing him back down, she went about feeding him breakfast. While she stood around watching him eat, she glanced over and realized she'd left her door unlocked all night. "We could've ended up on a true-crime podcast," she mumbled aloud as she corrected her error. Drunk Catra was an idiot.

She decided to do a quick walk around the apartment to ensure there wasn't an intruder lying in wait somewhere. After successfully clearing the bathroom, living room, and kitchen, the closet was the last place she needed to look. Her heart was racing as she waited to open it. This was so stupid, she admonished herself internally. Finally, she made herself swing it wide open and.... Nothing.

She laughed at her paranoia. Catra was definitely losing it. She started flipping through her clothes to pick something to change into after a very needed shower. She grabbed the first thing that called to her -- a blue and white plaid shirt. It wasn't her usual style and she couldn't even remember buying it, but it looked so terribly comfortable. After she got everything else together, she dragged herself to the bathroom and wondered how she would make it through school *and* work today.

A casual glance in the bathroom mirror stopped her dead in her tracks. Soon after she felt a painful shock that jolted from her spine to her brain. She blinked a few times and came closer to the mirror. As she stood face to face with herself, something felt off. She couldn't put her finger on it. She clutched the clothes close to her chest and focused on keeping her breathing slow and even. The longer she stared at herself, the worse the feeling became. She forced herself to close her eyes and focus on her thoughts. Head. Something was wrong with her head, and it wasn't simply the building migraine. She opened her eyes again and felt like the person she was looking at wasn't her. Something was *wrong* , and all of her instincts said it started with her head.

Cutting all of her hair off might have been a drastic solution to the sensation, but there wasn't any going back after the first big chop. Her small wastebasket began to fill with large portions of her curly, beautiful hair. When she was done, she ran her fingers through the messy shorter cut she'd given herself. She definitely would need to get it cleaned up professionally after work, but, for now, it felt like taking control over herself in this odd daze she was in.

School went by fine. Being there helped her feel more grounded, and her professors were even notably kinder and more personal with her. That was unusual but welcomed with the gloomy atmosphere of her mind. Work was fast-paced enough that she was distracted too. The routine of steam milk, cue shots, pump syrup, and repeat was comforting. She was in the middle of making her thousandth latte when Scorpia came over.

"Hey there, Wildcat. Love the hair! Big change, lots of changes... you know, in the world," she sounded oddly anxious talking to her, which was weird because they'd been cool since she started dating Perfuma. "How are you feeling today?"

"Fine," she answered before sighing and deciding it would be good to talk it out with someone, and she couldn't think of anyone else to go to. "The thing is I'm having a weird day on top of being hungover. Did we all go out after work and get trashed or

something? I can't remember a damn thing, and my phone's fucked, so I can't even see who I called or was with or whatever."

She gave an awkward smile and didn't answer at first. "Um, nope. Not us! We went out after the concert. You remember that, right? Right...?"

"Yeah," Catra shrugged and continued working. "I remember that fine up until I passed out at home. I don't know what's wrong with me. I don't overdo it like that."

"We all have our wild nights sometimes. Maybe you got a little carried away when you got home yesterday? A little one-woman party, I bet that was it." Scorpia patted her on the back. "I wouldn't think too hard about it. How, uh, how's your thinking going?"

"It's not today," Catra groaned before calling out the latte then turning back to her. "Everything's making me paranoid. I can't focus for shit. It all feels wrong," she looked at her with wide eyes, "Like this morning -- I was showering after I cut my hair, and I found a shampoo bottle that is not mine. It was for blonde hair. What the fuck is that about?! I started thinking about that serial killer who would break into people's homes and move stuff around."

Scorpia looked panicked, then laughed, "No big deal, Wild Cat. That's uh... Perfuma's. Yeah, that's it. I bet you picked it up in her car when you were drunk the other night."

"Oh," Catra scrunched her face up for a moment and considered it. "That makes me feel better. Maybe I'm not going crazy," she laughed. She happened to look up and catch sight of a woman coming into the cafe. She was *gorgeous*. "Swap spots with me? I wanna do register for a bit."

"Sure, no problem at all. Whatever you need! Happy to help," Scorpia said quickly and moved into position to take over drinks.

Catra wasn't one to flirt with customers. However, this woman, she would make an exception for. After working down the line, the blonde beauty was in front of her. She gave her smoothest smile. "Hey. What can I get started for you this morning?"

"Catra, we need to talk, please," she said with more emotion in her voice than Catra would've expected from customer interaction.

"Sure, if you have questions about the menu, I can help," she answered back, meeting her eyes and trying to determine what was going on.

"Fine, we can do this. I'll take a medium coffee," she huffed. Okay, blondie had an attitude. Maybe she was having a bad day.

"You're an easy one," she smirked. "What name can I put on that?"

"Seriously?! I can't believe you," she waved her hands out in front of her like she was dismissing the whole thing and stormed out of the store.

"Fuck me," Catra whined to herself as she watched her go. That's what she gets for trying to flirt. No wonder she hadn't done it... in... how... long. Why did that question feel so weird? As she tried to make sense of that feeling, her head started reeling, and she grabbed at her hair with a pained scream.

Scorpia hurried over and helped her stay on her feet. "Wildcat, can you hear me? Are you okay?"

"Yeah, yeah," she straightened back up. "It's my head; it's killing me all of a sudden."

"You should go on home if you're feeling bad. Perfuma will be here soon. We've got you covered, no problem at all. Do you think you can make it home?"

"Yeah, thanks. It's only a couple of blocks. Sorry," Catra sighed, giving in to this weird day finally. "Hopefully, I'll feel like myself

tomorrow."

Catra slowly made her way back home and collapsed into bed for a nap after downing a bottle of water. When she woke up, she felt ten times better already. It was funny. She couldn't even remember why she had gotten upset at the coffee shop anyway. Oh well. She set to work with a clearer mind writing an entire essay and cleaning her apartment. She was back in bed before midnight.

The next day of school and work passed without any incident. She met eyes with a cute blonde at the coffee shop but didn't get a chance to meet her before she slipped out. Damn. Her love life was really never going to take off. That point was made more evident as she started another Valentine's Day alone. Worse, she didn't have class or work to keep herself busy.

She laid in bed with Melog purring on her chest as she petted him and contemplated what to do with her day. For some reason, one word kept knocking around in her head. Eternia. She hadn't been to Eternia Beach since the summer before she started college. It was nice and all, but why did she want to go so badly now? In *February*. "Melog, you'd tell me if I was abducted by aliens or something, right?" She asked as though he would understand.

With nothing better to do, she decided to follow her gut and chase whatever it was leading her towards. Seemed better than laying in bed and eating junk food all day anyway. She got ready, packed up her sketchbook for some creative entertainment, and left her apartment. The train ride was quiet and empty once she got on the switch for the beach. No one else was thinking bitterly cold wind whipping around them would be the way to spend Valentine's. She found a spot to sit on some stairs and watch the sun as it continued its slow ascent. She began sketching the landscape in front of her when she caught sight of something interesting. A woman was walking the beach dressed like she was on her way to a business meeting--- with who, she wondered? A seagull? She lingered long enough that Catra had time to add her to the landscape.

After a while, she got hungry and decided to check out a diner she had seen on her way down. The waiter was entirely too peppy for her taste--- especially on a gloomy day like today. As she dug through her bag to get her headphones out, she came across an airplane bottle she had from the concert. Looking to make sure he wasn't paying attention, she opened it and quickly added it to her coffee. Only, someone did notice--- the beach-business blonde. She was seated a couple of tables from her, facing her with an amused smile. She raised her coffee with a wink, and that apparently was entirely too much for her to handle. She immediately turned bright red and started busying herself with a newspaper. Well, that's cute, she thought. With her art subject in front of her, Catra took her sketchbook back out and added more details while listening to music.

Before she got a chance to actually flirt with said woman, she was gone. That was Catra's luck. Only... there she was again at the train stop. She gave another wave and a flirty smile that totally wrecked the blonde. This was *fun*. Once they got on the train, she decided to make her move and sat right in front of the captivating stranger. After finishing up her sketch, she took a deep breath. Now or never. She popped up on her knees and looked back at the other woman. "Hey."

Glimmer felt like she had been holding her breath the entire time they waited for Entrapta to arrive. When there finally was a knock at the door, she jumped in surprise. "Bow, keep your phone ready," she instructed.

"Got it," he confirmed. "Wait, why? Do you think they're going to kidnap us all?"

"I don't put anything past these people," she narrowed her eyes. Her anxiety was lowered slightly when she opened the door was met with a cheerful woman with long lilac pigtails.

"You must be Glimmer, hi! I recognize you from their photos," she smiled and then gestured back at the lab cart she was pulling behind her. "Is it okay to enter?"

"Yes," Glimmer stepped back and helped her get the cart into the house. "This is my fiance, Bow," she gestured. "I guess you know that, though, huh?"

"Yes, Bow, hi!" She waved. "It's like meeting characters from a story. How fascinating! Where are the subjects?"

"They're sleeping," Bow positioned himself to be in front of the stairs to keep her from rushing up. "You don't get to see them until you tell us what happened and what you're going to do to fix it."

"Yeah, exactly," Glimmer crossed her arms and posted up beside him. "And don't try to lie; we know *a lot*."

Entrapta did not seem at all bothered by this request. She went to sit down in one of their armchairs and smiled, "Certainly! Where do you want me to start?"

"Um," Bow looked to Glimmer, clearly having expected more of a fight.

"Tell us about the day Catra came. What happened? We know she was sent there by her school."

"She was? Oh," she shrugged. "No one told me that. I didn't get to interact with Catra on a personal level. Normally, during brain mapping, there's a lot of prompting and conversation to get a precise map. However, Dr. Hordak had instructed me to speak to her as little as possible due to her mental health concerns. I remember that she was very picky about the handling of her items. It stood out to me because most patients don't care since they're going to be disposed of eventually."

Bow and Glimmer exchanged a look. "Go on," the latter prompted.

"Yes, so, we did the brain mapping, and I went back to work in my office. Then Dr. Hordak came and told me we would be doing her procedure in the facility. This is something we have *never* done before. You see, we usually go to our patient's homes, and they take the sedative on their own at their regular bedtime. It helps that they wake up in a familiar place and remember going to bed as usual. She was already under when I walked into his office. We began the procedure but were stalled for a long time shortly after we started. It was as though all the data we were seeking wasn't where it belonged."

"Is that what you meant by you thought she was fighting the procedure," Glimmer prompted.

"Yes, that and... well, she *woke up* during it. That was quite impressive! The sedative is designed to keep someone asleep for a whole night. I wanted to stop then and speak with her, but Dr. Hordak threatened to dismiss me. So, he sedated her further, and we were eventually able to get back on track. We had to work quickly because it was dangerous to keep her brain hooked up the way it was so long. I wonder if we missed something. That might be why she retained some spark that led to her finding of subject Adora again."

"So, wait," Bow looked disturbed as a thought occurred to him. "How did Catra get home? If you didn't leave her at the facility all night."

"Dr. Hordak and I took her home. It was quite tricky, but she is relatively light. Her cat is very cute." she rolled up her sleeve and showed a long scratch mark that was beginning to heal. "He did *not* like us. We put her in bed and left."

"Why is that the creepiest part of this," Glimmer mumbled to herself, then shook her head to refocus. "Okay. And Adora? What happened with her?"

"Her case was much more similar to our regular ones. Dr. Hordak did not give me any special instructions, so she and I conversed

quite a bit during her brain mapping. She was despondent about Catra's erasure of her. Everything was normal until that night, when we experienced the same sort of resistance to the procedure. However, we were able to right it more quickly with experience from Catra's. Again, I wanted to rouse and ask her about it, but Dr. Hordak was unwilling. I am beginning to think," she sighed, "That he has lost sight of the purpose of what we're doing. I want to help our patients. If subjects Catra and Adora were in fact resisting, we should've stopped."

"I definitely agree with that," Glimmer softened a little. It helped that the other woman seemed so willing to tell all. "We believe that Dr. Hordak is doing something even worse."

"I am willing to hear your theories, but unfortunately, time is of the essence if anything can be done. May I please speak with the subjects? Perhaps separate if possible? One of you may sit with us, of course."

The couple exchanged looks, and a wordless conversation only possible for people who have been together for so long. "Fine," Glimmer agreed. "Set up in our dining room."

"I'll go see if I can wake up Catra," Bow looked nervous. "I may have made this more complicated." He explained the whole handshake story.

"FASCINATING," Entrapta's eyes went wide. "Muscle memory, I never took that into account. I mean, that was quite dangerous of you, and I have *no idea* what ramifications it has had. I am eager to find out more! Her calmed state with the medication may be helpful."

Catra cracked open one eye in regards to the unwelcome disturbance in her Adora nap time. Bow was nudging her shoulder gently. "What do you want?" she said grouchily as she snuggled further into her soft sleeping partner.

"Um, so, remember the uh.. brain people?"

"Yeah, the bad brain people," she yawned. "That's what you said. Hurt your friend." She felt like there was more to it than that, but she couldn't grasp anything more.

"One of the brain people is good, isn't that nice? And she's here to talk to you. Can you do that?"

"Bow, why are you messing with me today," she groaned. "Do I have to do this right now? I'm so cozy."

"Hey," Adora had woken up by now, "You should go. It sounded like a great deal. We could um.. have a sleepover tonight at your place?"

"Mmm, okay," the brunette smirked as she held out a pinkie finger. "If you promise."

"I promise," Adora confirmed with the pinkie swear.

Bow anxiously started towards the door, "Alright! Let's go. Can't keep her waiting. Adora, do you mind waiting up here? They said that, um, there can't be distractions."

"Oh sure, no problem," she yawned.

"'You so distracting, Adoooora." Catra giggled and kissed her quickly before getting up.

When Catra entered the dining room, she was surprised to see that it was transformed into a mini-lab with all kinds of things strewn about. Huh. This was pretty serious. Interesting that they'd bring it all to a house. Glimmer was hanging out at the table too, and she waved when Catra came in.

"Hey Sparkles... hey, scientist lady," she said to the stranger in a lab coat. "Wanna talk about my brain?"

"Hello! My name is Dr. Entrapta, and yes, we're going to be talking about your brain. Is it okay if I put some sensors on you while we talk?"

"Sure, how else you going to see it, right? Not going to cut me open on the dining room table," she laughed too hard at herself. Man, this medication. She hoped her brain wouldn't disappoint from being too goofy.

The scientist finished hooking her up to some kind of machine and explained. "Alright, Catra. We are going to start with some visual cues. I'm going to hold up some items, and I would like to see if your mind has any association with them."

"Mmm, kay. Seems easy enough."

The scientist bent down and opened up a large tote beside her. From it, she drew a stuffed white horse with a blonde mane and shiny blue eyes. Catra stared at it and tried to focus on it. It was pretty cute. "Do I have to say stuff?"

"No! All you need to do is observe the item and allow your mind to wander where it may." Entrapta looked over at her computer screen and made some notations. "Okay, next item."

The scientist continued pulling things from the tote. It was bizarre; nothing seemed connected. There was a cowboy hat, a red jacket, a series of postcards, a race medal, dorky mugs, a necklace, some dorky t-shirts, all kinds of strange things. With each one, Catra did as instructed. Take it in. Allow her mind to wander. It was interesting. Most things generated images of Adora in her mind's eye. She was really falling hard for that girl. Maybe she'd ask about labels today. That would be smart.

"This one is small," Entrapta explained as she got up from her chair and came across to hand her a tiny box.

Catra opened it and stared inside. A ring. "It's beautiful," she noted as she took it out. It looked like a vintage piece, woven gold in geometric shapes that led to a central, bright blue stone.

Glimmer gasped, and Catra looked over at her in confusion. Before she could ask, the other woman covered her mouth and rushed out of the room. Weird. She was soon replaced by Bow, who looked a bit weepy.

"How's my mind looking," she asked after extended silence from everyone. She still held onto the ring, even though it was too big to fit any of her fingers well. It made her feel good in a way she didn't understand.

"Great," Entrapta answered finally as she looked up from her notations. "Can you tell me about your current partner?"

"Adora?" Catra asked. As soon as the name left her mouth, the scientist's eyes went wide, and she started working quickly. "We're not like, official, but I really like her. I think I love her. Is that weird? That's weird. It's been like two seconds," she laughed. She wouldn't be admitting were it not for the meds.

"That's nice," Entrapta said off-handedly once she finally finished whatever she was doing. "That's all I need from you right now, Catra."

Reluctantly, Catra put the ring back in the box and handed it over to be added back to the tote. After she was unhooked, Bow ushered her up to the guest bedroom where Adora was waiting.

"How'd it go, smartie," she asked after Catra crawled back in.

"Good, I think, maybe. It was *weird*. I got to look at some fun things."

"Actually, Adora. She would like to talk to you too. She's going to compare everyone's brains. How cool is that?"

"Ooh, someone's gonna look at dummy's brain," Catra teased as she squeezed Adora's head. "I think she's been hit up here too many times."

"Pfft, my brain is awesome. Now I'll have proof," Adora tickled her to get Catra to let go before getting up. "Maybe try to sleep more; you're still goofy."

"Bye Adora, love you," Catra mumbled as she curled back up in bed.

Adora probably should've asked more questions before allowing this stranger to do this, but Bow assured her everything was on the up and up. Glimmer was even sitting in the dining room with her and the doctor to watch it all. Maybe this was going to be a new party activity --- everybody, get your brain scans! She waited patiently for things to begin and hoped that Catra had already fallen back to sleep. As cute as she was being, it made her worried that something today upset her so badly she had to take that medicine.

"Are you ready to begin," Dr. Entrapta asked finally.

"Yep! What exactly are we going to do? Do I have to solve like.. puzzles, because I'm only really good at certain kinds," Adora laughed.

"I am going to show you some items, and all you have to do is observe them and allow your mind to wander as you do. Does that make sense?"

"Yeah, if there's one thing my mind can do, it's wander. Right, Glimmer," she smiled over to her best friend.

Glimmer had been staring with a blank look on her face but suddenly swapped to a smile, "You're a pro."

Entrapta reached down into one of two large trash bags she had sitting beside her. That's odd, Adora thought. All this expensive equipment on the go, and she's carrying stuff in trash bags. Not super professional.

The scientist would lay out a random item on the dining room table one by one, and Adora would stare at it. There were art canvases, mugs, a shirt for a place called Horse Dreams museum that she absolutely wanted to visit now, a necklace, a collection of concert tickets, and all kinds of things. With each item, Entrapta would take some notations. Such a strange process. The weirdest thing about it was how emotional it was making her feel. Slowly but steadily, she felt as though she was on the edge of tears. It reminded her of the feeling from Valentine's before she met Catra.

"How much longer will this take," her voice broke as she asked, and she did her best to conceal her emotion on her face.

"Only a few more things to go," Dr. Entrapta gave her a reassuring smile. "Everything is going well. Thank you."

Glimmer got up from where she was seated to give Adora a quick hug. "You're doing great."

"Thanks," she blinked away a few tears.

Finally, Dr. Entrapta noted that they were down to the last item. She placed a plush orange and brown tabby cat with blue and yellow eyes on the dining room table. Without asking permission, Adora immediately reached across and grabbed for it. As she held it in her hands, tears started flowing down her face. "I'm sorry," she sniffled. "I don't know what's wrong with me." Soft tears began to come out as choking sobs, and she clutched the plush to her chest. She was clearly losing her mind.

"Adora, what's wrong," a welcomed voice came from the doorway. Before she even answered, Catra wrapped her arms around her from behind and kissed her wet cheek. "I'm here. You're okay."

She turned her head to look up at Catra, and like a tub whose stopper was removed, all of the sadness started flowing out of her. "I am now," she gave a little laugh. "My brain is very dramatic, I think."

"Is she done?" Catra asked the scientist.

"Yes, actually," Dr. Entrapta had been working fiercely as soon as Catra walked into the room. "I believe I have all the data I need for you two."

"Can I keep this," Adora asked, still clutching the plush to her chest, "I'll pay you for it. I really like it. And... well, I've cried all over it."

"Absolutely," Dr. Entrapta smiled. "No charge."

Catra started giggling once she took the item in, "She's recently learned about cats. Hey! Look, she's got my eyes."

"That's why I love her," Adora confirmed.

"Alright, ladies," Glimmer called. When Adora looked over, she swore she looked like she'd been crying too. "How about we get into some of my terrible TV while Bow gets his study done?"

"Sounds good," Adora looked up at Catra. "Are you up for it?"

She laughed, "Definitely. I'm extra funny right now."

While Glimmer was distracting Catra and Adora with the reality show binge, Bow and Entrapta talked in hushed voices in the dining room.

"As you can see," Entrapta explained as she showed three different images of Catra's brain-- before the procedure, after, and now. "The connections are still there and quite strong. When she said her name, it all lit up like a neural Christmas tree! Adora's was very much the same as soon as Catra entered the room."

"That's great," Bow allowed himself to believe. "Can you fix it?"

"I have an idea, but... I'm afraid it would be unethical to proceed under these false pretenses."

"Entrapta," Bow groaned. "Catra had this done to her under false pretenses." He grabbed his copies of the emails, false websites, and more that he had printed. "It's obvious once you put it all together with your story. She didn't know what was happening to her. He took advantage of her and wanted to use her as another *success* story. He even wanted her to come back today to fix her, I'm sure."

Entrapta sat silently, reading over everything for a few minutes before she said sadly, "This is terrible. I had no idea. My creation wasn't supposed to be used this way."

"Then let's fix it," Bow begged.

Entrapta nodded, "I am more than willing to try. The problem is, we are heading into uncharted territory with this technology. If it were to go wrong, and either subject were to be harmed... It would be very unethical, as unethical as what has already happened if they weren't informed of the risks."

"What you're saying is... We're going to do what you've been adamant we shouldn't do to be able to fix this."

"Precisely. We must tell them the truth and allow them to choose what course of action to take," she grabbed for another small tote she had brought with her, "I withheld some items from their initial scans because they contain photos and their writing. These and the recordings of their personal narratives should be enough to push past any skepticism like you reported from Catra this morning. It should be grounding... or break their sense of reality. Or both. But there's only one way to find out."

"This is, without a doubt, the weirdest fucking dinner party I've ever been to," Catra cackled. She was laid across Adora's lap on

the couch as the blonde stroked her hair. Her daze from the medication was beginning to wear off.

Dr. Entrapta had set up in the living room, her lab cart in front of her as a portable desk. "What I am going to explain to you now may be very upsetting," she began. "If at any time you require a break, please let me know, and we will stop."

"And we're here for you two, okay," Glimmer assured them. She and Bow were sharing the armchair and watching. "We love you."

"Uh, thanks, Sparkles," Catra laughed.

"Are you about to give us electric shock therapy or something," Adora asked with raised eyebrows.

"No, but this will be shocking in its own way," Entrapta sighed. "I am going to start with playing you some recordings. These were done at our facility, Prime Enterprises, within the last week. The first is of one of my associates and his interview of one of our patients."

She hit play on her recorder.

Male Voice: Why don't you begin by telling me about how this conflict began? Why did it have such a severe impact on your emotional state?

Female Voice: It was stupid, actually. My girlfriend and I were supposed to go to a concert together. We'd bought tickets for it months in advance, and then something came up at work. When she couldn't go, I invited a coworker to go along with her girlfriend.

"What the fuck is this," Catra sat up from Adora's lap in a hurry. "That sounds like me. What's going on?"

Entrapta had paused the recording. "I will explain. Is it okay if I continue playing this recording?"

"Fine, whatever," she huffed. Adora reached out and held her hand.

Catra: The problem was... the coworker I invited, she used to have a big crush on me. I thought my girlfriend knew she was dating someone else. I guess not because I came back to her place, and she was pissed. Accused me of leading her on and all this shit. I was really drunk, and I didn't handle it well. The thing is, we've *never* had that kind of 'yelling at each other' type fight before. Even after I sobered up, it hurt. It hurt that she would think that about me. I love her so much. I'd never want to be with someone else or hurt her like that. If she could think I would do that... it really sent me spiraling. And I couldn't talk to her about it, so that made it worse. That's why I want to do this. If what you're saying is true, you can help me with handling my emotions better... then I can be better for myself *and* Adora. I want us to have a future, you know. I can't shut her out every time we have a fight.

"Were you talking about me," Adora looked to Catra. "I don't understand."

"I don't either, Adora, I promise." Catra groaned. She started holding her head in her hands. "Fuck, it hurts. None of this makes sense."

"My apologies. As I said, this will be difficult. I am going to play you another recording now. This is of myself and a second patient," Dr. Entrapta began.

Dr. Entrapta: Why are you here?

Female Voice: Because... I don't know what else to do. I can't imagine going through my life and knowing Catra doesn't even remember me anymore. I'm never going to stop being in love with her. I don't trust myself not to try to see her... to fix this. And I can't do that to her. I already hurt her enough to cause this. If she's done with me, I need to let her go. It'll be better for us both if I don't remember either.

Entrapta paused the recording. "You both were my patients. At Prime Enterprises, we offer a procedure that allows for the suppression of unwanted memories. My intention was to help people move on and be happier. I see now that wasn't what was happening. Catra, your friends," she gestured over to Glimmer and Bow, "And I believe you were falsely led into this procedure. I hadn't reviewed your intake tape until now, and it's quite clear to me that you didn't intend to erase Adora. Obviously, she was not aware when she volunteered for our services. Both of you showed remarkable resistance to the procedure, as though you were trying to stop it."

"This... is real," Adora finally spoke up after hearing her own voice on the recording.

"It is," Glimmer confirmed. "I'm so sorry."

Catra still seemed resistant. "How do I know you're not all fucking with me? They have things where you can make it sound like people said whatever you want." She even looked at Adora suspiciously now, having scooted away from her on the couch.

Entrapta opened up the final small tote and placed it on the coffee table in front of them. "The items I showed you earlier were what you brought to help us with the brain mapping procedure. I took these out because I knew they would be too triggering."

Catra's eyes grew wide as she started to sift through the tote. Photos of herself and Adora doing all kinds of things along with Glimmer and Bow too --- domestic and mundane, vacations, beautifully dressed up for events. As hard as she tried, she couldn't formulate a memory about any of them. It was like looking at photos of an identical twin she didn't know she had. "Fuck," was all she said as she slid the box over to Adora and leaned back on the couch. Tears were rolling silently down her cheeks as she stared up at the ceiling.

Adora did much the same. Finally, she looked up with anger in her eyes along with tears, "You took this away from us. Fuck you and

this whole place. We should call the police or something. This is so wrong. How could you do this to her?"

"I didn't know," Entrapta was shaking her head low. "I developed the science, but I never intended it to be used this way. I'm here now because I want to fix this. I believe I can undo some of the damage. It may not be perfect, but I analyzed you both earlier. The connections are there. It is possible. Of course, I would need your consent to proceed."

"NOW you need my permission to fuck with my brain," Catra started laughing darkly. "I can't believe this. I really can't. WHY did you do this to me?! I'm sure there are plenty of people stupid enough to volunteer for this shit."

"It's complicated, Catra," Bow said softly. "We think it has something to do with your advisor, Dr. Hordak. His brother is the one who runs the clinic."

"He was the one who told me about this scholarship thing," Catra started to put it all together, her mind becoming sharper. "Oh my god. He was going to do it again. It was all bullshit."

"Unfortunately, yes," Dr. Entrapta frowned. "I had nothing to do with that. I swear."

Adora gazed over at Catra sadly before turning back to the scientist. "We could have our memories back, but... there's a chance it won't work? Or it might hurt us?"

Dr. Entrapta nodded, "Precisely."

Catra shook her head. "We need to talk about this alone, okay? Please."

Glimmer spoke up quickly, "Take all the time you need. We want you to be sure."

Bow started tearing up as he added, "If you don't want to do the procedure, we'll support you. We can tell you stories about the

past instead, whatever you want."

With that, Catra and Adora retreated to the guest room away from everyone else. After sitting on the bed in silence for a while, Catra spoke up first with a little laugh, "What the fuck, right?"

"Seriously," Adora sniffled. "Remember when we were just going to do laundry today?"

"I never thought I'd be nostalgic for laundry day," she wiped away some of the tears that were still on her face. "It um.. looked like we had a pretty nice life together."

"Yeah, we did," she placed a hand over her heart and closed her eyes, "I can't remember it, but... I can *feel* it. I've felt it since I met you. I thought it was so weird to be attached so fast."

"None of this makes a damn bit of sense except how I feel about you." With that, Catra leaned in and pressed their lips together in a soft, familiar kiss. "If you're willing to try to do this, I am."

"But what if we do this and then we see that we were going to break up or something? Apparently, we had this big dumb fight and I feel like it was my fault."

Catra shrugged. "I don't know, dummy. If we love each other enough to win against sci-fi level bullshit like this, I think we stand a chance to make it through anything."

"Okay," Adora smiled. "Let's do this."

Steel-blue eyes opened to the sun beginning to creep in through the windows. Beside her, she heard a chorus of rhythmic purring and soft snores. When she rolled over to look at the sources, Adora smiled as she took the sight of Melog sleeping on her girlfriend's chest. They were too cute. Wait... suddenly, she started to process the night prior. Dr. Entrapta had been with them before they went to sleep.

"Catra," she asked softly, "Wake up."

"Why dummy, I'm sleepy," the other woman groaned. Melog hopped up to go await breakfast. "Five more minutes."

"Catra, how did we meet," Adora was almost afraid to hear the answer. What if it worked for her, but not Catra? She'd make it work. She could teach her about their past if she had to. It was worth it.

Finally, Catra answered groggily, "You and that dumb kite at the beach." After a moment, it seemed to hit her too. "And we both had the same ridiculous rainbow cat phone case. You took me to meet Bow and Glimmer right then because you said we were meant to be. They're getting married in June."

"I'm Glimmer's maid of honor, and you're Bow's best man. You wouldn't let him change the title because you thought it sounded cooler," Adora confirmed happily. She climbed on top of her girlfriend and kissed her with such desperation she lost her breath. "It worked," she cheered, planting more kisses on her face.

"It worked," Catra wrapped her arms around her and pulled her in as though she might disappear. "I can remember this past week too, but like I'm recalling a movie or something. It doesn't feel real," she shook her head before she got an amused look on her face. "Bow and Sparkles. You introduced me to them like they didn't know me. They must have been so fucking confused," she started cackling. "When we go over later, do it again. I wanna appreciate their reactions this time."

"You're evil, you know that?" The blonde teased.

"Uh-huh, and you love it," she gave a smug smile. "What now?"

"Now..." Adora hummed to herself as she thought. "Now, we go back to being idiots in love. And... we sue those Hordak assholes."

"They're paying for my grad school one way or another." After another round of laughs, Catra sighed contently as she stared into the eyes of her girlfriend. "I love you, Adora. I never want to lose you again."

"I love you too," she squeezed her tightly. "I'm going to handcuff you to me. That's the only solution."

"Not the *only* solution," Catra mused. "You stay here. I'm going to go feed Melog and grab something."

Chapter End Notes

> Emotionally this has been my most challenging piece. I'm proud of how it turned out. Of course, endings are always tough to stick the landing on. I'm fairly satisfied with it, but I am curious to know what other folks think! Thank you for reading.
>
> Note: I didn't want to belabor the scientific process of what Entrapta ultimately does to fix it, because... well, frankly, I'm not a scientific mind! In my head, it looks very similar to what they did before since I set up that all the memories were still there but inaccessible for their recall. So maybe they had done something that damaged/blocked the access, and Entrapta healed/reversed it

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